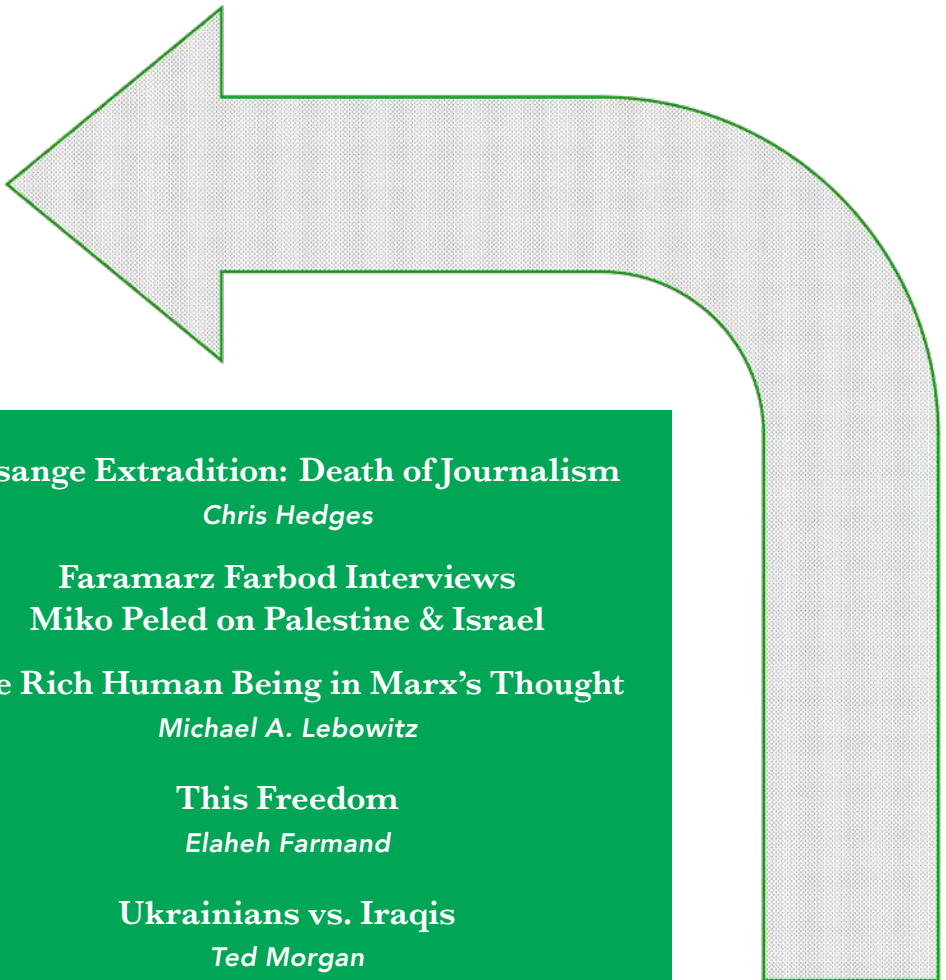


Left Turn

A Quarterly Journal of Critical Voices



Assange Extradition: Death of Journalism

Chris Hedges

**Faramarz Farbod Interviews
Miko Peled on Palestine & Israel**

The Rich Human Being in Marx's Thought

Michael A. Lebowitz

This Freedom

Elaheh Farmand

Ukrainians vs. Iraqis

Ted Morgan

China's BRI & a Hybrid International Order

Gary Olson

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Notes from the Editor

“All journalists are Julian Assange.” This should be the universal motto of every journalist and publisher. Assange, the founder of Wikileaks, is undoubtedly the most accomplished journalist/publisher of our time and is dangerously close to being extradited to the US for trial and imprisonment for life. It is important to point out that Assange has engaged in journalistic practices no different than any other journalist worth their calling. Investigative Journalists routinely encourage their sources to provide information of critical importance to the public. They protect the identity of their sources. They may even encourage their sources to break the law and leak classified information to prevent greater state crimes. But the US Justice Department alleges that Assange unlawfully helped Chelsea Manning, the former US Army intelligence analyst, to steal classified diplomatic cables and military files and published them in 2010. The US has indicted Assange on 18 counts of violating the Espionage Act. Under the Espionage Act, Assange will not be allowed a defense by ruling out the relevance of motive on his part. If extradited, he will surely rot in a maximum-security prison for life.

In this issue of *Left Turn*, we reprint an article by journalist and author Chris Hedges (titled “The Imminent Extradition of Julian Assange and the Death of Journalism”) about the pending extradition and the trial. As Hedges makes abundantly clear, far more is at stake than silencing a courageous truth-teller. If the US succeeds in convicting and imprisoning Assange, it will have taken a giant leap toward killing investigative journalism altogether, especially the kind that seeks to expose the inner workings of the powerful and the crimes of the US national security state. As Hedges explains, Assange is guilty of exposing a series of war crimes, illegal spying, backing a bloody coup, and other official corruption by the US that have embarrassed high officials of the state. That is his ‘sin,’ and they are not about to forgive and forget.

The US intends to criminalize truth-telling by making an example of Assange. It wants to immunize the state officials who engage in massive war crimes, international gangsterism, state terrorism, and corruption from public scrutiny and challenge. It fears the possibility of even a minimally functioning democracy based on an informed and civic-minded citizenry. It aims to criminalize truth-telling while leaving those re-

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The Imminent Extradition of Julian Assange and the Death of Journalism

Julian Assange's legal options have nearly run out. He could be extradited to the U.S. this week. Should he be convicted in the U.S., any reporting on the inner workings of power will become a crime.

CHRIS HEDGES

High Court Judge Jonathan Swift—who previously worked for a variety of British government agencies as a [barrister](#) and [said](#) his favorite clients are “security and intelligence agencies”—[rejected](#) two applications by Julian Assange’s lawyers to appeal his extradition last week. The extradition order was [signed](#) last June by Home Secretary Priti Patel. Julian’s legal team has filed a final application for appeal, the last option available in the British courts. If accepted, the case could proceed to a public hearing in front of two new High Court judges. If rejected, Julian could be immediately extradited to the United States where he will stand trial for [18 counts of violating the Espionage Act](#), charges that could see him receive a 175-year sentence, as early as this week.

The only chance to block an extradition, if the final appeal is rejected, as I expect it will be, would come from the European Court of Human Rights ([ECtHR](#)). The [parliamentary arm](#) of the Council of Europe, which created the ECtHR, [along with](#) their Commissioner for Human Rights, oppose Julian’s “detention, extradition and prosecution” because it represents “a dangerous precedent for journalists.” It is unclear if the British government would abide by the court’s decision—even though it is obligated to do so—if it ruled against extradition, or if the U.K. would extradite Julian before an appeal to the European court can be heard. Julian, once shipped to the U.S., would be put on trial in the U.S. District Court for the Eastern District of Virginia where most espionage cases have [been won](#) by the U.S. government.

Judge Vanessa Baraitser at Westminster Magistrates’ Court [refused](#) to authorize the U.S. government’s extradition request in Jan. 2021 because of the severity of the conditions Julian would endure in the U.S. prison system.

“Faced with the conditions of near-total isolation without the protective factors which limited his risk at [Her Majesty’s Prison] Belmarsh, I am satisfied the procedures described by the U.S. will not prevent Mr. Assange from finding a way to commit suicide,” said Baraitser when [handing down](#) her 132-page [ruling](#), “and for this reason, I have decided extradition would be oppressive by reason of mental harm and I order his discharge.”

Baraitser’s decision was [overturned](#) after [an appeal](#) by U.S. authorities. The High Court [accepted](#) the conclusions of the lower court about the increased risk of suicide and inhumane prison conditions. But it also accepted four [assurances](#) in U.S. Diplomatic Note no. 74, given to the court in Feb. 2021, which promised Julian would be well treated. The U.S. government claimed that its assurances “entirely answer the

concerns which caused the judge [in the lower court] to discharge Mr. Assange.” The “assurances” state that Julian will not be subject to Special Administrative Measures ([SAMs](#)). They promise that Julian, an Australian citizen, can serve his sentence in Australia if the Australian government requests his extradition. They promise he will receive adequate clinical and psychological care. They promise that pre-trial and post-trial, Julian will not be held in the Administrative Maximum Facility (ADX) in Florence, Colorado. No one is held pre-trial in ADX Florence. But it sounds reassuring. ADX Florence is not the only supermax prison in the U.S. Julian can be placed in one of our other Guantanamo-like facilities in a Communications Management Unit (CMU). CMUs are highly restrictive units that replicate the near-total isolation imposed by SAMs.

None of these “assurances” are worth the paper they are written on. All come with [escape clauses](#). None are legally binding. Should Julian do “something subsequent to the offering of these assurances that meets the tests for the imposition of SAMs or designation to ADX” he will, the court [conceded](#), be subject to these harsher forms of control.

If Australia does not request a transfer it “cannot be a cause for criticism of the USA, or a reason for regarding the assurances as inadequate to meet the judge’s concerns,” the ruling read. And even if that were not the case, it would take Julian 10 to 15 years to appeal his sentence up to the U.S. Supreme Court, which would be more than enough time to destroy him psychologically and physically.

No doubt the plane waiting to take Julian to the U.S. will be well stocked with blindfolds, sedatives, shackles, enemas, diapers, and jumpsuits used to facilitate “[extraordinary renditions](#)” [conducted](#) by the CIA.

The extradition of Julian will be the next step in the slow-motion execution of the publisher and founder of WikiLeaks and one of the most important journalists of our generation. It will ensure that Julian spends the rest of his life in a U.S. prison. It will create legal precedents that will criminalize any investigation into the inner workings of power, even by citizens from another country. It will be a body blow to our [anemic democracy](#), which is rapidly metamorphosing into [corporate totalitarianism](#).

I am as stunned by this full frontal assault on journalism as I am by the lack of public outrage, especially by the media. The very belated [call](#) from *The New York Times*, *The Guardian*, *Le Monde*, *Der Spiegel*, and *El País*—all of whom published material provided by WikiLeaks—to drop the extradition charges is too little too late. All of the public protests I have attended in defense of Julian in the U.S. are sparsely attended. Our passivity makes us complicit in our own enslavement.

Julian’s case, from the start, has been a judicial farce.

Former Ecuadorian President Lenin Moreno terminated Julian’s rights of asylum as a political refugee, in violation of international law. He then authorized London Metropolitan Police to enter the Ecuadorian Embassy—a diplomatically sanctioned sovereign territory—to arrest a naturalized citizen of Ecuador. Moreno’s government, which revoked Julian’s citizenship, was [granted a large loan](#) by the International Monetary Fund for its assistance. Donald Trump, by demanding Julian’s extradition under the Espionage Act, criminalized journalism, in much the same way Woodrow Wilson did when he [shut down](#) socialist publications such as *The Masses*.

The hearings, some of which I [attended](#) in London and others of which I sat through online, mocked basic legal protocols. They included the decision to ignore the CIA's surveillance and recording of meetings between Julian and his attorneys during his time as a political refugee in the embassy, eviscerating attorney-client privilege. This alone should have seen the case thrown out of court. They included validating the decision to charge Julian, although he is not a U.S. citizen, under the Espionage Act. They included Kafkaesque contortions to convince the courts that Julian is not a journalist. They ignored Article 4 of the [U.K.-U.S. extradition treaty](#) that prohibits extradition for political offenses. I watched as the prosecutor James Lewis, representing the U.S., gave legal directives to Judge Baraitser, who promptly adopted them as her legal decision.

The judicial lynching of Julian has far more in common with the dark days of [Lubyanka](#) than the ideals of British jurisprudence.

The debate over arcane legal nuances distracts us from the fact that Julian has not committed a crime in Britain, other than an old charge of breaching bail conditions when he sought asylum in the Ecuadorian Embassy. Normally this would entail a fine. He was instead sentenced to a year in Belmarsh prison and has been held there since April 2019.

The decision to seek Julian's extradition, [contemplated](#) by Barack Obama's administration, was pursued by the Trump administration following WikiLeaks' [publication](#) of the documents known as Vault 7, which [exposed](#) the CIA's cyberwarfare programs designed to monitor and take control of cars, smart TVs, web browsers and the operating systems of most smartphones, as well as Microsoft Windows, Mac OS and Linux.

Julian, as I [noted](#) in a column filed from London last year, is targeted because of the Iraq War Logs, released in Oct. 2010, which document numerous U.S. war crimes, [including](#) images seen in the *Collateral Murder* video, of the gunning down of two Reuters journalists and 10 other civilians and severely injuring two children.

He is targeted because he made public the killing of nearly 700 civilians who had approached too close to U.S. convoys and checkpoints, including [pregnant women](#), the blind and deaf, and [at least](#) 30 children

He is targeted because he [exposed](#) more than 15,000 unreported deaths of Iraqi civilians and the [torture and abuse](#) of some 800 men and boys, aged between 14 to 89, at Guantánamo Bay detention camp.

He is targeted because he [showed us](#) that Hillary Clinton in 2009 ordered U.S. diplomats to spy on U.N. Secretary General Ban Ki-moon and other U.N. representatives from China, France, Russia, and the U.K., spying that included obtaining DNA, iris scans, fingerprints, and personal passwords, all part of the long pattern of illegal surveillance that included eavesdropping on U.N. Secretary General Kofi Annan in the weeks before the U.S.-led invasion of Iraq in 2003.

He is targeted because he [exposed](#) that Obama, Hillary Clinton, and the CIA backed the June 2009 military coup in Honduras that [overthrew](#) the democratically-elected president Manuel Zelaya, replacing him with a murderous and corrupt military regime.

He is targeted because he [released](#) documents that revealed the United States secretly launched missile, bomb, and drone attacks on Yemen, killing scores of civilians.

He is targeted because he [made public](#) the off-the-record talks Hillary Clinton gave to Goldman Sachs, talks for which she was paid \$657,000, a sum so large it can only be considered a bribe, as well as her [private](#) assurances to Wall Street that she would do their bidding while [promising](#) the public financial regulation and reform.

For revealing these truths alone he is guilty.

The U.S. court system is even more draconian than the British court system. It can use SAMs, anti-terrorism laws, and the Espionage Act to block Julian from [speaking to the public](#), being released on bail, or seeing the "secret" evidence used to convict him.

The CIA was created to carry out assassinations, coups, torture, kidnapping, blackmail, character assassination, and illegal spying. It has targeted U.S. citizens, in violation of its charter. These activities were exposed in 1975 by the Church Committee hearings in the Senate and the Pike Committee hearings in the House.

Working with [UC Global](#), the Spanish security firm in the embassy, [the CIA put](#) Julian under 24-hour video and digital surveillance. It discussed [kidnapping and assassinating](#) him while he was in the embassy, which [included](#) plans of a shoot-out on the streets with involvement by the London Metropolitan Police. The U.S. [allocates](#) a secret black budget of \$52 billion a year to hide [multiple types](#) of clandestine projects carried out by the National Security Agency, the CIA, and other intelligence agencies, usually beyond the scrutiny of Congress. All these clandestine activities, especially after the attacks of 9/11, have massively expanded.

Senator Frank Church, after [examining](#) the heavily redacted CIA documents released to his committee, [defined](#) the CIA's covert activity as "a semantic disguise for murder, coercion, blackmail, bribery, the spreading of lies."

The CIA and intelligence agencies, along with the military, all of which operate without effective Congressional oversight, are the engines behind Julian's extradition. Julian inflicted, by exposing their crimes and lies, a grievous wound. They demand vengeance. The control these forces seek abroad is the control they seek at home.

Julian may soon be imprisoned for life in the U.S. for journalism, but he won't be the only one.

Chris Hedges is the former Middle East bureau chief of the New York Times, a Pulitzer Prize winner, and the author of several books, including America: The Farewell Tour, American Fascists and War Is a Force That Gives Us Meaning.

Faramarz Farbod Interviews Miko Peled on Palestine & Israel

[Partial transcript of an interview on [Berks Community Television](#), April 11, 2023.]

Faramarz Farbod: Can you explain what you mean by Zionism?

Miko Peled: To put it as simply and succinctly as possible, Zionism is an ideology that says the Jewish people all over the world have a right to Palestine at the expense of Palestinians. It created a theory that because all Jewish people around the world are descendants of ancient Hebrews a few thousand years ago, they have a right to return. And that the Jews are not a nation united by religion, but a nation united as all other nations by a land, a country, a history, and so on, which, of course, is completely antithetical to Judaism. According to Judaism and Jewish law, what unites Jews is their faith, the laws, the Jewish laws, not language or a country. Anyway, the Zionists were secular people. They said we are a nation like all nations, our country is Palestine, and our history is the Old Testament. They believed in the religious part of the Old Testament, but they said we can throw out God and all that nonsense. But the history there, that's our history. I grew up and learned that history, the stories of the Old Testament; we learned them as history.

That's Zionism, and it says that I and every Jew around the world, well, I certainly, because I was born there, but any Jew around the world, has the right to come to Palestine, and they call it Israel, the land of Israel.

FF: That is the so-called Right of Return, which is extended to the Jews but not to the Palestinian inhabitants who were displaced.

MP: Yes, of course. The Palestinians were considered, and are considered, invaders, foreign invaders. It's our land, we may have been gone for two thousand years but we are back. You know, the use of 'we were there and now we are back' and so this is us. The reason I think this is absurd is that if you ask any Israeli Jew "Where are you from?" they'll say Ukraine, Poland, Russia, Iraq, Yemen, Kurdistan, Maghreb, Iran, and every other place in the world. But you ask any Palestinian outside of Palestine "Where are you from?" — ask any child, you know that I go to conferences and there are always a lot of children — they say: Yafa, Haifa, Jerusalem, and so on. They know the name of the villages up and down the country. These people are all from there. But take Bezalel Smotrich, the far-right Israeli Minister of Finance, who is the most rabid, racist Zionist, perhaps in the history of Zionism. His name is the name of a town in Ukraine. He has this rant that goes on telling Palestinians that they are Arabs and that there is no such thing as Palestinians. They're just Arabs and they need to go back to Arabia. If their name is Messrie (Egyptian in Arabic) then they need to go to Egypt, and so on. But *his* name is Smotrich, and he hasn't even changed it. It shows the absurdity of this whole idea of the right of Jewish people to return to a place they never came from.

That is what Zionism is. It's the ideology that created an apartheid regime in Palestine that gives privileges to Jews at the expense of the Palestinians. That's what it

is. It's a racist ideology. It's a violent ideology. And what we see today is that ideology being manifested.

FF: We could say Zionism is a violent ideology not because it is theoretically a violent ideology. If there was a place without a people where this in-gathering of Jews from around the world could take place, then it would not require any violence. But because Palestine was inhabited by the Palestinians, Zionism in practice necessarily became very violent. It also required sponsorship by global powers, earlier Great Britain, and later the United States. Otherwise, there would be no state of Israel the way we are experiencing it as a settler-colonial, apartheid state.

MP: It also required this new notion, a new creation of a secular Jew — historically a new thing. For Jews, the yearning to go to Jerusalem was always for prayer and worship. It had nothing to do with sovereignty. Jews never sought and, in fact, according to Jewish law, are prohibited from sovereignty in the Holy Land. There is a famous line by a Rabbi, an Egyptian who lived in Baghdad, Iraq, in the 12th century, that every practicing Orthodox Jew knows. He wrote it in Arabic using Hebrew letters, discussing religious issues as part of a famous treatise. He wrote that the Jews are a nation united by their sharia, their religious laws. That's it. Zionists came up and said, no. You don't have to be religious. It has nothing to do with religion; we are a nation, and on and on.

So, that's what Zionism is, and as you said, there is no way it could go without violence. This is why they created this mantra: "A land without a people for a people without a land." First, this was a Christian mantra before it became a Jewish Zionist one; the Christian Zionists preceded the Jewish Zionists in the early 19th century. But it is not that they didn't know there were people living in Palestine, but these were people who didn't matter because they are brown. They are not European. This is a Eurocentric settler-colonial ideology that made perfect sense at the time. It's like people say, Balfour promised Palestine to the Jewish people by giving a note to a Jewish millionaire by the name of Rothchild. Who the hell is Balfour and who the hell is Rothchild and what the hell have they got to do with giving and taking Palestine and promising it to anybody? But they are two white racist Europeans talking about the land that belongs to brown people. They could do that, and it was perfectly acceptable at the time.

FF: You are referring to the Balfour Declaration in 1917. I agree. Even Theodore Herzl (the founder of modern Zionism) who argued for the immigration of Jews to Palestine to form a Jewish state in response to European anti-Semitism, wrote in his 1896 book, *The State of the Jews*, that a Jewish state in Palestine would be "an outpost of civilization against barbarism," betraying the European colonial and racist mentality of the times.

MP: Herzl also talked about how disgusting Jews are and how the Zionist is a new Jew who is good-looking and looks more like the Greek ideal of what a human should look like. He wrote some terrible things about Jews that no one would dare say today. If you look at his writings, it's quite horrifying the way he and some other early Zionists describe Jews.

FF: I wonder why? Is that because he was looking down on the condition of Jews who had lived in ghettos? Is that what he was associating that image with?

MP: He was disgusted by Jews. He hated Jews. He couldn't help the fact that he was a Jew. You must read his writings. He had this idea that you must break away from this ugly, filthy, thieving Jew, and create this new image of the Zionist Jew who is good-looking, tanned, brave, fights for their rights, cultivates the land, is enlightened, speaks an enlightened language, and so on. Many early Zionists, the whole generation of my father, what's called the 1948 Zionists who were born in Palestine, hated the Jews, hated the image of the European Jew, which was somebody who is subservient to God, follows what they perceive as God's laws, lives in a secluded way in a way that they can worship and not be interrupted, and refuses to carry guns. To this day, the Orthodox community in Palestine refuses to serve in the military, and they get hate, they get arrested, they get beaten, and they get persecuted terribly by the Israeli authorities for their stance which is a very honorable moral stance of refusing to carry arms and participating in this military thing. But the Zionists look down on these people. Even at one point, they said, we are creating the state but not for these people. We are creating the state for this enlightened Jew, not for this backward Jew. So there are a lot of very strong antisemitic overtones in early Zionism.

FF: It's ironic that by now the enterprise of Zionism in a way has led to this turnaround in Israeli politics towards the rise of nationalistic religious Zionism at the expense of let's say a more pragmatic, Ashkenazi, labor party-type Zionism that dominated in the first several decades of the establishment of the Jewish State. I wonder what Herzl and other early Zionists might have said if they were alive to witness this turn of events moving from this secular Jew to now this rising dominance of Zionist type or character of nationalistic and religious Jews, a settler from the West Bank.

MP: Who knows what people like Herzl would have said? When you look at it historically, what we see today does not represent a shift or change. I think it's a very natural succession of Zionism up to this point. People talk about how, as you said, they used to be kind of secular and socialist-oriented. But we can't forget that this secular, socialist-oriented ideology was established over a massive campaign of ethnic cleansing and genocide, a genocidal campaign against another nation. And then when they established the state, the few Palestinians who remained in Palestine were put in ghettos. They were not second-class citizens but people with no rights. In the West, people thought it was this wonderful thing; it was a miracle. In the 70s and the 60s, young Americans and young Europeans would go and volunteer on the Kibbutz. And the Kibbutz was this idealistic creation. But, of course, the land and the water were stolen, and labor was cheap. The Palestinian farmers who were thrown out of their land were now hired at starvation wages to cultivate the land for these Ashkenazi settlers. So, yes, there was this sense that it was idealistic, and they presented it that way in the West. But the truth was very different. Look at the current Israeli cabinet and government. They are the true representation of Zionism.

FF: You could say they are the case of Zionist chickens who have come home to roost.

MP: Yes. You know, you got the hundreds of thousands of Israelis protesting. Why are they protesting? This is the 40 or 45 percent of Israelis who did not vote for the people who are in government power right now. They were quite happy and satisfied when these settlers terrorized Palestinians in the West Bank. They belong in the

West Bank. They don't belong on the national scene. They don't belong as ministers in our lives. They belong to these rowdy, ugly people that we don't like and don't want to associate ourselves with. These 40 or 45 percent in the streets do not see themselves as settlers; they do not see themselves as people who committed war crimes going on for 75 years. The other Israelis have. Now these other Israelis are back like you say they are turning to roost. Now they are in the government. They hold nationally important positions. They create policies that touch on everybody. That's why Israelis are so angry now and protesting in the streets because they don't like the face of these people. It's like looking in the mirror and discovering that you are terribly ugly.

FF: So, it's like tension between let's say liberal Zionism and religious, ultra-nationalistic Zionism of settler kind. Is this essentially what we are seeing?

MP: Yes, although I would use the word 'liberal' cautiously because all they care for is their own privilege within the apartheid regime. This does not extend to anybody other than Israeli Jews.

FF: Right. That's why when people say 'Israel is the only democracy' in the Middle East, they are really talking about at best a closed utopia, for the Jews only. We cannot call Israel a democratic state when you have the ongoing occupation of Palestinians and the apartheid practices as acknowledged by Amnesty International, Human Rights Watch, Harvard Law School, B'Tselem, not to mention Palestinian sources.

MP: Of course not.

FF: In a September 2022 U.N. Report by Ms. Francesca Albanese, the current Special Rapporteur about human rights in the Palestinian territories occupied since 1967, she argued that the denial of the right of the Palestinian people to self-determination constitutes the very heart of the injustice in Palestine. This denial is the key reason why we have this terrible situation in Palestine today.

MP: Yes. A couple of years ago, the new Rapporteur that you mentioned co-authored an excellent paper called "Palestinian Refugees in International Law" and she asked me to write a review that I published. It talks about claims of Palestinian refugees. Not only have they not become weaker over the years; they have become stronger over the years. It shows exactly what was taken from Palestinians in 1948 beyond just their homes and their land. We are talking about public spaces, cities, produce that was on the fields and trees, and you know billions were stolen and what the value of that is today and what Israel owes Palestinians to this day. Because there is an attempt to delegitimize the Palestinian claims to return and to reparations, saying only the Palestinians who were alive in 1948 and were displaced have any rights of refugees. She shows that is legally untrue and that people don't realize just how much the Zionists stole. People had money in the banks. People had cars. Farmers had agricultural equipment. There was produce in the fields. There were fruits on the trees. There were entire cities, public spaces, theaters, schools, and hospitals, and all of this was taken and stolen to create houses and apartments. These were big cities. The Zionists came and said that there is nothing here and that we made the desert bloom. You know the Negev, which is a fertile desert, if you look at aerial photos the British took in the 1920s you see enormous plots of land that were cultivated. Israel did not make anything bloom. They went on a rampage and stole and destroyed. They have

continued the destruction to this day. I am glad that you mentioned her because she coauthored this important paper.

FF: That's why the Palestinians say that the land was furnished when the Zionists came and took it. Palestine was not empty neither of people nor riches.

MP: That's right.

FF: Let's get to the current protests and the new government in Israel. There have been months of protests in Israel against the judicial reforms that Netanyahu, the Prime Minister of Israel, has been pushing for. Currently, it has been delayed. But part of the news of the delaying of the push for the overhaul of the judicial reforms by Netanyahu was that he gave Itamar Ben-Gvir, the Minister of National Security of Israel, who had opposed the delay, his own so-called private militia, or a new national guard. People like Ben-Gvir and the settlers who follow him have been going around saying to the Palestinians they terrorize that they are going to give them a second Nakba. That's a word that Palestinians use to describe the catastrophe that befell them in 1948 when they lost their land, homes, and their history. This poses a tremendous problem for the security of all Palestinians in the coming months.

MK: Yeah, I mean there is a discussion about guaranteeing the safety and security of the Palestinians. They are the ones that are being killed regularly for over 75 years. They are the ones who are endangered. But the narrative and the discourse are always about the safety of the Jews and the Israelis. And that's kind of what justifies the \$3.8 billion going from the US to Israel and they milk that to the bone. It's the Palestinians who need some kind of guarantee for their lives and safety. Again, it was always the case. Now, it is even worse. Netanyahu supposedly made a promise that he was going to put a hold on these judicial reforms, which most people call a coup, not judicial reform. But nobody believes him. I don't believe him. He says one thing and does another quietly. This is how they operate. The protests are not stopping. But you do hear voices from people who work in the Ministry of Health and the Ministry of Education that their budgets have been sliced and slashed to provide funding for Ben-Gvir's new Army which is some kind of new militia. The lives of the Palestinians have always been in danger since Israel was established. Now it's much more severe. The lives of every Palestinian are in danger all the time. They were saying that this militia would only deal with terrorists and political issues. In other words, every Palestinian child with a rock is a terrorist. Anyone who rejects Zionism, the state of Israel, or what it does is a supporter of terrorism. You and I would be in that category. Every other Palestinian would be in that category.

The Palestinian citizens of Israel are probably the most cooperative, quiet, educated, and as a community contributing to society and the well-being of others. They are all going to be terrorists now. We are talking about Palestinian Bedouins in the Negev, some 300,000 people, the Palestinian citizens of Israel in general, about 2 million, any activists within that community, and any politician who runs against the settlers. The settlers control the municipalities, and city councils, and are now getting more control of the military and the police. Palestinians are on the edge of a precipice without any question, and nobody is speaking for them. Nobody is talking about how to guarantee *their* safety and security. It's never part of the conversation. It's a very serious problem. There is always this expectation, expression, and discourse that 'the

Palestinians need to...,' 'the Palestinians should...,' and 'if only Palestinians could...'. Well, the Palestinians are in a maximum-security prison. They are doing everything they possibly can. There is not going to be another Salaheddin, Messiah, or God knows who is going to come and save them.

If we allow our representatives to send the money to Israel, they will continue to do so. If we allow our representatives to identify with Zionism, which is a racist, brutal ideology, then they will continue to do so. If we tell them to stop and demand they stop, then there is a chance they will stop. But we hold the keys. The other thing is we always hear that Israelis are people of conscience. But we saw liberal Israelis in the hundreds of thousands in the streets and never heard one voice calling to end the blockade of Gaza or allow the allocation of the same amount of water to Palestinians who are not allocated water. That is not part of the conversation at all. Two hundred fighter pilots refused to show up for duty as reservists. When did they ever refuse to bomb Gaza? So, we cannot look up to Israeli society; help is not going to come from them. These are the most liberal people that we are seeing in the streets now, and this is not a part of their agenda. So, it's up to us. People on the outside must help the Palestinians.

FF: Yes, that's why the Palestinian Israelis are not part of these protests. After all, what if you secure the independence of the courts in Israel? They have not been nice to the Palestinians with home demolitions and all sorts of other issues. Nobody is talking about their issues; Palestine is the elephant in the room here.

Let's talk about the US-Israel relationship. Why does the US support Israel when all human rights organizations say Israel subjects the Palestinians to a brutal system of oppression and apartheid? We still have Biden saying that he is a Zionist and a friend of Israel. The US goes on to support Israel with the \$3.8 billion that you mentioned in terms of money but also with all the other layers of US support: diplomatic, political, using the US veto in the UN, strategic, economic, integrating some of the US high-tech industry with that of Israel, intelligence-wise, ideological, and so on. Why do you think that is? Is it due to a very effective PR machine at work, the Israeli lobby, or is it an imperative of the American Empire, maybe Israel is a watchdog for the US in the region, or a combination of all these?

MP: It is all the above. People imagine the Israeli lobby as a bunch of people in suits at the Capitol. That's how Israel operates. The Zionists learned very early on, a hundred years ago, that in America all politics is local. That is why anybody who runs for city council, school board, or any mayor, police chief, or deputy-police chief, regardless of how small the town is, immediately gets a trip to Israel, which includes a helicopter ride with some famous General over the Golan Heights, and visits here and trips there in jeeps and so on. They have been investing in cultivating politicians, making sure that schoolbooks, textbooks, and social studies portray the issue of Israel-Palestine the way they want it done. They got watchdog organizations throughout the entire country looking at and reading social studies textbooks. They are in the black and Latino churches. They are taking delegations of young black leaders again to Israel. They have got these organizations where Zionist Jews sit with black Americans talking about their mutual suffering. You know, one of the most privileged groups in America sharing suffering with probably one of the most disenfranchised

groups in America and the world. They have been doing this for a hundred years. They have pockets without limits. They are very good at it. On top of that, about half of the foreign aid bill comes back to purchase weapons, and the whole issue of shared values of two countries that are built on racism and genocide. So, it is a combination of all the things that you mentioned.

FF: I am glad you mentioned the ‘shared values’ because when people here in the US mention it they mean that we are both democracies, that we both respect human rights and the rule of law, and so on. But, as you said, it is the values of racism and settler colonialism that both countries share.

Lastly, do you see any difference between the Democratic Party and the Republican Party when it comes to relations with Israel and the US support for it?

MP: No. Not at all. This is a bi-partisan issue and will always be one because it has nothing to do with politics. It is above politics.

FF: Some poll data suggest the rank-and-file of the Democratic Party has shifted its perspective on this issue but not the establishment of the party. Bernie Sanders pointed to the Israeli violence against the Palestinians and refused to attend the AIPAC gathering when he was invited. These developments point to an opening of sorts at least among the rank-and-file of the party. But like you, I don’t see any shifts in the establishment of the party.

MP: Yes, I think it is marginal. There is some shift in the margins. But in the larger scheme of things, I don’t think there is any difference here. I think the problem is that nobody is speaking for the other side at any level. There is no Palestinian presence in Washington, D.C. Nothing, not one, zero. There are a couple of little NGOs located in basements in Virginia and other places but there is no presence at all. Nobody is speaking seriously for Palestine anywhere in this country. So, it does not matter. I mean, if there was a presence and they were speaking and doing a good job of it, then the whole bi-partisan support could shift.

FF: Thanks, Miko for joining me. And thank you for your honesty, defiance, and empathy, and for seeing the Palestinian other as human. These are qualities that we need if we are to bring about positive changes in Palestine. We need to see your example replicated.

MK: Thank you very much for inviting me to your program.

Miko Peled is an Israeli-American activist, author, international speaker, and karate instructor.

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The Rich Human Being: Marx and the Concept of Real Human Development

MICHAEL A. LEBOWITZ

Editor’s Note: We mourn the loss of Michael Lebowitz who died at home on April 19, 2023. Mike was a superb Marxist economist, teacher, and author of many valuable works about Marx, the socialist project, and capitalism. Perhaps it is not an exaggeration to say that Mike more than any of his contemporaries contributed to reviving Marx’s ideas about workers’ self-liberation and real human development. We are publishing an unpublished paper he wrote in preparation for Marx Conference held in May 2004 in Havana, Cuba. Michael Lebowitz, presente!

With the introduction of the UN Human Development Reports and the development of the Human Development Index (published annually by the UNDP since 1990), much-needed attention was directed to measures specifically related to the welfare of human beings rather than to statistics on income and production. In particular, levels of health and education were added to income measures as indicators of the relative ability of particular societies to provide people with an environment in which they could develop their potential. And, the results of these measures demonstrated that societies such as Cuba, Kerala, and Costa Rica rank much more highly in providing these conditions than states with comparable income levels. In this respect, here (as in the case of an earlier emphasis upon ‘basic needs’) the focus shifted from economic growth as such to human beings.

Yet, the Human Development Index (HDI) is an example of a model which is impoverished relative to the theory which underlies it. The Human Development Reports draw upon the work of Amartya Sen—in particular, his emphasis upon the development of human capabilities as the condition for people to function in many ways and to take advantage of opportunities for well-being (Sen, 1992:40). The HDI, however, does not attempt to measure human capability as such but primarily tells us about the effect of government priorities for expenditures. Thus, while statistical measures of characteristics such as health, education, security, and human rights may identify preconditions for the ability of people to develop, in themselves they serve only as proxies for the potential growth of capabilities and do not demonstrate the realization of that potential. Neither do these studies focus closely on the precise process by which human capabilities develop.

Marx and Human Capacity

Emphasis upon both the development of human capability and the process by which this occurs, though, was always at the core of Marx’s perspective. Right from the outset of his work, he rejected the preoccupations of the political economists of his time and envisioned a ‘rich human being’—one who has developed his capacities and capabilities to the point where he is able ‘to take gratification in a many-sided way’—‘the rich man profoundly endowed with all the senses’ (Marx, 1844b: 302). ‘In place of the wealth and poverty of political economy,’ the Young Marx pro-

posed, ‘come the rich human being and rich human need. The rich human being is simultaneously the human being in need of a totality of human manifestations of life—the man in whom his own realization exists as an inner necessity, as need (Marx, 1844b: 304).

It was not only the Young Marx, however, who spoke so eloquently about rich human beings. In the *Grundrisse*, Marx returned explicitly to the conception of human wealth that he had articulated earlier. “In fact,” he asked, ‘when the limited bourgeois form is stripped away, what is wealth other than the universality of individual needs, capacities, pleasures, productive forces, etc., created through universal exchange’ (Marx, 1973: 488)? In envisioning a rich human being—‘as rich as possible in needs, because rich in qualities and relations—... as the most total and universal possible social product’, Marx (1973: 409) revealed his understanding that real wealth is the development of human capacity. And, this concept of capacity involved more than simply the development of ‘capabilities of production’; it encompasses as well the development of ‘the capabilities as well as means of consumption’ because the development of the ability to enjoy is ‘the development of an individual potential’ (Marx, 1973: 711).

For Marx, in short, there was no contradiction between saying, on the one hand, that ‘real wealth is the developed productive power of all individuals’ and, on the other, that ‘regarded materially, wealth consists only in the manifold variety of needs’ (Marx, 1973: 527, 708). Rather than thinking of a being with simple needs and simple productive powers, Marx looked to the ‘development of the rich individuality which is as all-sided in its production as in its consumption’ (Marx, 1973: 325).

This is what Marx’s conception of communism was all about—the creation of a society which removes all obstacles to the full development of human beings. He looked ahead to that society of associated producers, where each individual is able to develop his full potential—i.e., the ‘absolute working-out of his creative potentialities,’ the ‘complete working out of the human content,’ the ‘development of all human powers as such the end in itself’ (Marx, 1973: 488, 541, 708). In a communist society, the productive forces would have ‘increased with the all-round development of the individual, and all the springs of co-operative wealth flow more abundantly’ (Marx, 1875: 24). The result, in short, would be the production of rich human beings. ‘What is the aim of the Communists,’ Frederick Engels asked in a draft for the *Communist Manifesto*? He answered, ‘To organize society in such a way that every member of it can develop and use all his capabilities and powers in complete freedom and without thereby infringing the basic conditions of this society.’ In the final draft of the *Manifesto*, Marx presented this goal as necessarily indivisible—as an ‘association, in which the free development of each is the condition for the free development of all.’

Production of Human Capacity as a Labour Process

But, how does this development of human capacity occur? Marx had one consistent answer. Human beings develop through all their activities. As the French Marxist Lucien Sève (1978: 304, 313) commented, ‘Every developed personality appears to us straight away as an enormous accumulation of the most varied acts through time’, and those acts play a central role in producing human ‘capacities’—‘the ensemble of

“actual potentialities”, innate or acquired, to carry out any act whatever and whatever its level.’

Both within an organized labor process as well as away from such a process, people develop their capacities. ‘It goes without saying,’ Marx (1973: 712) commented, ‘that direct labor time itself cannot remain in the abstract antithesis to free time in which it appears from the perspective of bourgeois economy.’ ‘Time for education, for intellectual development, for the fulfillment of social functions, for social intercourse, for the free play of the vital forces of his body and his mind’ is time when people are engaged in different kinds of production (Marx, 1977: 375). ‘Every kind of consumption,’ Marx pointed out, ‘in one way or another produces human beings in some particular aspect;’ thus, when ‘attending lectures, educating his children, developing his taste, etc,’ the worker expands his capacities in different dimensions (Marx, 1973: 90-1, 287; Lebowitz, 2003a: 66-72). In short, those who have this opportunity to develop their capacities differently transform themselves and enter ‘into the direct production process as this different subject.’ From this standpoint, free time can be regarded as ‘the production of fixed capital, this fixed capital being man himself’ (Marx, 1973: 712).

People also produce themselves, however, when the development of their capacities is not their preconceived goal. ‘The coincidence of the changing of circumstances and of human activity or self-change’—here is the essence of Marx’s view of ‘the self-creation of man as a process’, an understanding he drew initially from Hegel but which always remained central to his perspective (Lebowitz, 2003a: 178-81). Marx was most clear on this point when talking about the struggles of workers against capital and how this revolutionary practice transforms ‘circumstances and men’, expanding their capabilities and making them fit to create a new world (Lebowitz, 2003a: 180-3). His point, though, was not at all limited to the process of struggle. In the very act of producing, Marx noted in the *Grundrisse*, ‘the producers change, too, in that they bring out new qualities in themselves, develop themselves in production, transform themselves, develop new powers and new ideas, new modes of intercourse, new needs and new language’ (Marx, 1973: 494). The worker as the outcome of his own labor, indeed, enters into Marx’s discussion in *Capital* of the labor process—there the worker ‘acts upon external nature and changes it, and in this way, he simultaneously changes his own nature’ (Marx, 1977: 283).

In short, every act of production, every human activity, has as its result a joint product—both the change in the object of labor and the change in the laborer herself. Of course, there are obvious differences between a labor process in which the development of human potential is the goal and one in which changes in human beings appear as a residual effect of the process of capitalist reproduction. The social relations characteristic of the labor process necessarily shape the changes in the capacity of the producers. Thus, in capitalist production, human capacity develops as an unintended consequence, a joint product, of capital’s attempt to drive beyond all barriers to its growth. The ‘ceaseless striving’ of capital to grow, Marx (1973: 325) argued, is why, compared to its predecessors, the rule of capital ‘creates the material elements for the development of the rich individuality.’ The daily activity of people in pre-capitalist societies—‘the traditional, confined, complacent, encrusted satisfac-

tions of present needs, and reproductions of old ways of life' restricted the expansion of human capacities. Capital's civilizing mission, thus, was to destroy these barriers to human development: It is destructive towards all of this, and constantly revolutionizes it, tearing down all the barriers which hem in the development of the forces of production, the expansion of needs, the all-sided development of production, and the exploitation and exchange of natural and mental forces (Marx, 1973: 410).

Similarly, capital creates the material elements for expanded human capacity insofar as it transforms the existing mode of production into one appropriate to its needs. New forms of cooperation among producers introduced by capital provide conditions in which the worker 'strips off the fetters of his individuality, and develops the capabilities of his species' (Marx, 1977: 447). Further, with the development of large-scale industry, capital's need for 'the fitness of the worker for the maximum number of different kinds of labor' provides historical conditions for the emergence of 'the totally developed individual, for whom the different social functions are different modes of activity he takes up in turn' (Marx, 1977: 618). Indeed, the capitalist drive for surplus value 'spurs on the development of society's productive forces, and the creation of those material conditions of production which alone can form the real basis of a higher form of society, a society in which the full and free development of every individual forms the ruling principle' (Marx, 1977: 739). However, while Marx (1973: 325, 409-10) understood that capital strives in this way toward universality, producing 'this being as the most total and universal possible social product,' he was very clear that capital produces its own barriers to the production of rich human beings.

The Production of Poor Human Beings

Within capitalist relations of production, people are subjected to 'the powerful will of a being outside them, who subjects their activity to his purpose.' The creative power of the worker's labor in this case 'establishes itself as the power of capital, as an alien power confronting him' (Marx, 1977: 450; 1973: 453, 307). Thus, fixed capital, machinery, technology, all 'the general productive forces of the social brain', appear as attributes of capital and as independent of workers (Marx, 1973: 694; 1977: 1053-4, 1058). As a by-product of its drive for surplus value, capital produces people who are dependent upon capital and who are conscious of that dependence—'a working class which by education, tradition, and habit looks upon the requirements of that mode of production as self-evident natural laws' (Marx, 1977: 899; Lebowitz, 2003a: 156-58). And, with the development of capitalist production, that dependence grows: 'the world of wealth expands and faces him as an alien world dominating him, and as it does so his subjective poverty, his need and dependence grow larger in proportion' (Marx: 1977: 1062).

In this respect, capitalism does not produce a rich human being but an impoverished one: a person with the need to buy things, a person with one real need—the need for money. In capitalism, Marx commented, 'this complete working-out of the human content appears as a complete emptying-out, this universal objectification as total alienation, and the tearing-down of all limited, one-sided aims as sacrifice of the human end-in-itself to an entirely external end' (Marx, 1973: 488). So long, too, as

they accept the logic of capital 'as self-evident natural laws,' workers are simply the products of capital—'apathetic, thoughtless, more or less well-fed instruments of production'. However, Marx understood that struggles to satisfy their needs as socially developed human beings were another product of capitalist production—i.e., capitalism produces class struggle on the part of workers. As workers organize to struggle for themselves, i.e., engage in a process of purposeful activity and subordinate their will to their preconceived goals, they transform themselves into subjects with the capacity to build a new world (Lebowitz, 2003a: 179-84).

Marx's Capital and Rich Human Beings

Unfortunately, Marx said very little about the specific characteristics of these new subjects in this new world. Nevertheless, there is an obvious place to discover his concept of rich human beings. Once we understand Marx's consistent focus on human development, it is clear that the premise of Marx's *Capital* is the concept of communism, that society in which the development of all human powers is an end in itself. This 'society of free individuality, based on the universal development of individuals and on the subordination of their communal, social productivity as their social wealth'—communism—is the specter that haunts Marx's *Capital* (Marx, 1973:158). Its presence can be felt right from the opening disparagement of capitalism as a society in which wealth appears not as real human wealth but, rather, as 'an immense collection of commodities' (Marx, 1977: 125). Indeed, the concept of communism drops from the sky without any logical development in *Capital* when Marx (1977: 772) evokes a society characterized not by the capitalist's impulse to increase the value of his capital but, rather, by 'the inverse situation in which objective wealth is there to satisfy the worker's own need for development'.

We need to recognize that this 'inverse situation' that Marx introduces is the perspective from which Marx critiques capitalism. Consider his description of the fact that means of production employ workers as 'this inversion, indeed this distortion, which is peculiar to and characteristic of capitalist production'. An inversion and distortion of what? Simply, the 'relation between dead labor and living labor' in a different society, one in which the results of past labor are 'there to satisfy the worker's own need for development' (Marx, 1977: 425).

Accordingly, by identifying the inversions and distortions that produce truncated human beings in capitalism, we can get a sense of Marx's idea of what is 'peculiar to and characteristic of' production in that inverse situation, communist society. We can understand what the rich human being is by seeing its inversion. Not only do we see Marx reject the mutilation, the impoverishment, the 'crippling of body and mind,' of the worker 'bound hand and foot for life to a single specialized operation' in the capitalist process of manufacturing but we also can see the horror with which he views the further advance of capitalist machine industry which provides a technical basis for the capitalist 'inversion', completing the 'separation of the intellectual faculties of the production process from manual labor' (Marx, 1977:482-4, 548, 607-8, 614). Head and hand become separate and hostile, and 'every atom of freedom, both in bodily and in intellectual activity' is lost. 'All means for the development of production undergo a dialectical inversion,' he indicated; 'they distort the worker into a

fragment of a man,' they degrade him and 'alienate from him the intellectual potentialities of the labor process'—these are just some of the distortions characteristic of capitalist production (Marx, 1977: 548, 643, 799). In short, in addition to producing commodities and capital itself, the joint product of capitalist production that Marx identified was the fragmented, crippled human being whose enjoyment consists in possessing and consuming things.

There can be no surprise, then, that Marx looked to the re-combining of head and hand, the uniting of mental and physical labor, to restoring a situation in which the individual worker calls 'his own muscles into play under the control of his own brain.' By 'combining education and gymnastics with manual labor'—here was 'the germ of the education of the future;' it was 'the only method of producing fully developed human beings' (Marx, 1977: 613-4, 643). The answer was 'variation of labor, fluidity of functions, and mobility of the worker in all directions'—this is what is meant by the development of human capacity. The partially developed individual, he argued, 'must be replaced by the totally developed individual, for whom the different social functions are different modes of activity he takes up in turn' (Marx, 1977: 617-8).

At the core of all this is the importance of variety, variety of activity—people develop their capabilities only through their own activity. Through new acts which allow for the growth of their specific capacities, through that 'accumulation of the most varied acts through time' to which Sève refers. In this way, they produce in themselves the potentialities to carry out other acts which reproduce and expand their capabilities. When they are denied the opportunity to exercise these potentialities, however, they do not develop—which is precisely what Marx recognized was inherent in a society in which human beings exist as means for the expansion of capital. Where the interconnection of workers in production 'confronts them, in the realm of ideas, as a plan drawn up by the capitalist, and, in practice, as his authority', workers cannot develop their potential as human beings. Without 'intelligent direction of production' by workers, without production 'under their conscious and planned control,' their own power becomes a power over them.

It is not accidental, accordingly, that Marx indicated that the 'revolutionary ferments whose goal is the abolition of the old division of labor stand in diametrical contradiction with the capitalist form of production' (Marx, 1977:619). Just as with the capitalist state, the 'systematic and hierarchic division of labor' characteristic of capitalist production, with its own 'trained caste' above workers ('absorbing the intelligence of the masses and turning them against themselves in the lower places of the hierarchy') does not permit the 'all-round development of the individual' (Marx, 1977: 173, 450, 482; Lebowitz, 2003a: 193–96). Just as with the concept of the self-government of the producers that workers 'at last discovered; during the Paris Commune, rich human beings are the product of a labor process which is characterized by 'the people—acting for itself by itself' (Lebowitz, 2003a:196).

The 'Becoming' of Communism

What are the implications of this conception for the building of communism? In both communism as an organic system and also communism in the process of becoming, every labor process produces joint products—particular use-values and

particular producers. Certainly, once it develops upon its own foundations, communism would produce the human beings who are the premises of the system itself. Once the idea of producing directly for the needs of others becomes 'by education, tradition and habit' common sense, the activity of people no longer is 'dominated by the pressure of an extraneous purpose which must be fulfilled, and the fulfillment of which is regarded as a natural necessity or a social duty'; at that point, it becomes free activity—the creative manifestation of life arising from the free development of all abilities of the "whole fellow"—i.e., 'life's prime want' (Marx, 1971: 257; Marx and Engels, 1976: 225) People produce here in the knowledge that their activity is important to others in the society and they are thus affirmed in their selves. They produce not only use-values but also themselves as social human beings, as rich human beings—the premises of communism as an organic system (Marx, 1844a; 1973: 278).

Just as certainly, however, communism as it first emerges does not spontaneously produce its own premises. In particular, as discussed in my paper for the conference last year (and published in Marx Ahora), the initial defect of communism, the self-interested behavior rooted in the private ownership of labor-power, inherently endangers solidarity within the society. The claim of associated producers upon society's output in accordance with 'the labor they supply' rather than by their membership in society not only generates inequality but also carries within it the tendency toward the disintegration of the common ownership of the means of production (Lebowitz, 2003b). Insofar as producers view their work primarily as a means to secure desired use-values (i.e., are driven by consumerism), the nature of the people produced in the process is that of people for whom other people are mere means to get money. Precisely because human consciousness cannot change as rapidly as the property rights to things, overcoming the private ownership of labor power is more difficult than overcoming the private ownership of the means of production.

For this reason, the 'becoming' of communist society must be understood as a process which challenges the spontaneous tendencies present in communism as it first emerges. There are a number of aspects to this. Firstly, recognition that every labor process generates joint products—both the change in the object of labor and the change in the laborer herself—points to the error in the assumption that the development of rich human beings is the project for some distant realm of freedom, the error of assuming that everything depends upon the development of the productive forces. In contrast to earlier periods when 'the development of human abilities and social potentialities (art, etc., science)' had as its premise the surplus labor of the masses and 'free time on one side corresponds to subjugated time on the other side,' the organization of production by the associated producers themselves permits the development of a mode of production which provides the opportunity for the development of human abilities and which, by reducing alienation, reduces the need to possess things (Marx and Engels, 1988: 190-92).

Of course, the associated producers will choose the length and intensity of a workday which will leave them time and energy for their own personal development. However, the 'time at society's disposal for the intellectual and social activity of the individual' is not limited to time away from production (Marx, 1973: 706; 1977: 667). If the nature of the labor process is such as to fragment and cripple the producer, she is distorted, fragmented, and crippled away from that labor process as well. By

ending the separation of ‘the intellectual potentialities of the labor process’ from the producers, communist society breaks with the old pattern in which ‘the development of the human capacities on the one side is based on the restriction of development on the other side’ (Marx, 1973: 711; Marx and Engels, 1988: 190-92).

A second aspect to the process of the ‘becoming’ of communism, though, is that it is essential to recognize that the labor process should not be confused with the production of specific use-values. In a society which focuses on human beings something that could only be revealed in capitalism by analysis is here transparent—all specific products and activities are mere moments in the process of producing human beings, the real result of social production. As Marx commented about capitalism: When we consider bourgeois society in the long view and as a whole, then the final result of the process of social production always appears as the society itself, i.e., the human being itself in its social relations. Everything that has a fixed form, such as the product, etc appears as merely a moment, a vanishing moment, in this movement (Marx, 1973: 712).

Thus, not only the production of specific material commodities (in the so-called ‘productive sector’) but also educational and health services, household activity which directly nurtures the development of human beings, community maintenance—all these are recognized as integral parts of the process of producing the social beings who enter into all these activities (Lebowitz, 2003: 200-202). And, that points to the importance not only of making each moment a site for the collective decision-making and variety of activity that develops human capacities but also for building relations of solidarity in all these moments. The act of solidarity has joint products—it both provides support for the needs of others and produces rich human beings. Acts of solidarity express the indivisibility of the development of human capacity in that ‘association, in which the free development of each is the condition for the free development of all.’

The process of producing the premises of communism as a reproducing, organic system, in short, removes the veil that mystifies the organic links between the limbs of the collective worker. The associated producers, Marx commented, expend ‘their many different forms of labor-power in full self-awareness as one single social labor force’ (Marx: 1977, 171). We see the rationality of solidarity between all those limbs of the collective worker to the extent that this production by freely associated human beings ‘stands under their conscious and planned control’ (Marx, 1977: 173). And that necessity for conscious and planned control points to an essential aspect of that process of becoming: if the plan is to be their power rather than a power over them, then the goals of the labor process must be transparently, in the realm of ideas, the result of their own plans and, in practice, their own authority. The starting point of the communist labor process, in short, is the democratic conception of the plan; and the essential joint product of this process is the production of the capacity for ‘intelligent direction of production’—a premise of Marx’s notion of rich human beings.

Real Human Development

Real human development for Marx went far beyond anything that the UN Development Program attempts to measure in its Human Development Reports. The idea of human capacity that Marx advanced was one that stressed the actual develop-

ment of human ability—the idea of ‘the totally developed individual, for whom the different social functions are different modes of activity he takes up in turn.’ Variation of labor, and mobility of the producer in all directions, points to capacities which, once developed, can be applied to new challenges, to the overcoming of new obstacles which is ‘in itself a liberating activity’ and, thus, a process of self-realization (Marx, 1973: 611).

But, what kind of activities produce this rich human being whose ‘own realization exists as an inner necessity, as need?’ How are these capacities produced? For Marx, it is from the process of co-operation itself. As he indicated, ‘when the worker co-operates in a planned way with others, he strips off the fetters of his individuality, and develops the capabilities of his species’ (Marx, 1977: 447). In short, the process of collective decision-making, of collective problem-solving, of ‘self-working and self-governing communes’ (Lebowitz, 2003a: 194) produces real human development.

No one could ever suggest, however, that data on variables such as literacy, life expectancy, etc at all approach the richness of Marx’s concept of human development. However useful they may be, these are not the measures of the rich human beings of communist society. Where is the measure for the self-confidence in people that is created through the conscious development of cooperation and democratic problem-solving in communities and workplaces? How can we measure the sense of solidarity with others that comes from the simultaneous changing of circumstances and self-change when activity is focused on the needs of people?

If we share Marx’s vision of rich human beings, we need to promote his concept of human capacity rather than speak about human capital, which obscures the nature of capital as a social relation based upon exploitation. Further, we face two challenges—that of working to develop measures which reflect this concept of human capacity and, especially, that of working to create the conditions which permit the self-development of those rich social beings.

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This Freedom

ELAHEH FARMAND

I came to America,
25 years ago
with rose-colored glasses,
a suitcase of memories,
and my mother's dreams
unfolded.

I came to America
with little English
and a lot of bitterness because
our struggles as new immigrants
embarrassed me.

But I came to America
with my mother's hopes
and from her,
I learned that we were lucky,
privileged,
to be living
the American Dream.

I am grateful, but...
this freedom is not equal for every body
this freedom destroys Mother Earth and builds walls
this freedom demands documents as proof of humanity
this freedom has us placing signs on our windows and back yards: "Hate
has no home here."

This freedom has become an immigrant's nightmare: black and brown
children in cages,

Latina mother in a coma on the brink of deportation
Immigrant women undergoing forced hysterectomies
This freedom is the terror of ICE:
Immigration and Customs Enforcement.

This freedom manufactures
consent that our enemy,
is an Iraqi or an Afghani or
another brown body.

This freedom betrays
and cries crocodile tears
while waging wars under disguise
of human rights.
This freedom attacks
our rights to our bodies
our books in our schools.
This freedom will
chase away
all that remains
of a once American dream
I come from Iran,
where dreaming is forbidden, and execution arbitrary
where a ticket to America is a ticket to heaven
my parents brought me here so that I could be free
so that I could dream and be who I want to be
And yet here I am,
shaking with anger
"My body, my choice!"
this poem continues to get longer
this freedom reminds me of the very place I left
This freedom breaks my heart.

Elaheh Farmand is an Iranian immigrant and writer. In 2016, she founded the series, "Immigrants & Exile: Stories of Nostalgia & Longing". The series gives space for people to share their experiences of nostalgia, exile, and longing. Elaheh fights for and dreams of a society restructured to place people's needs and wellbeing before profits. She is occasionally nostalgic for her childhood in Iran, but focuses her energy on organizing, connecting with her community, her family and friends.

Ukrainians vs. Iraqis: Worthy and Unworthy Victims

TED MORGAN

Paramount among the responsibilities of a free press is the duty to prevent any part of the government from deceiving the people and sending them off to distant lands to die....

Justice Hugo Black, in the Pentagon Papers case.

In their 1988/2002 classic, *Manufacturing Consent: the Political Economy of Mass Media*, Edward Herman and Noam Chomsky presented a “propaganda model” whereby the corporate media “serve to mobilize public support for the special interests that dominate the state and private activity.”¹ Key to their analysis were five “filters” that collectively filtered out of mass media perspectives that challenged fundamental premises or suggested the systemic roots of state power —i.e., the filters effectively excluded forms of “illegitimate,” or one could say radical discourse. The authors provide detailed case studies of each of the filters at work.

Herman and Chomsky labeled one such filter as “worthy and unworthy victims,” noting that people abused by (or in) “enemy states” are *worthy* of intensive and often dramatic coverage by the corporate media, whereas people abused by the United States or its allies or client states are *unworthy* of mass media attention. They illustrate their argument by comparing *New York Times* coverage of the 1984 murder of a Polish priest by (Communist) Polish police with the murders of several priests, Archbishop Romero, and four American church women and other religious figures by the U.S. client states, El Salvador and Guatemala. The effect was to legitimize two murderous regimes backed by the United States, while simultaneously reinforcing propaganda about the evils of the nation’s communist adversaries.

At a time when current mass media are filled with reports and images from the war in Ukraine, and coincidentally a time when the media have been reflecting on the 20th anniversary of the US invasion of Iraq, it’s hard to imagine a more potent example of worthy and unworthy victims in mass media coverage than the Ukrainians and Iraqis. Not that there aren’t countless Ukrainian victims of the brutal Russian assault but that the paired examples have one thing in common: *the US corporate media systematically reinforce the legitimacy of American imperialism*. In the mass media world, US objectives in providing massive military support to help the Ukraine defend itself against a brutal invasion and “evil dictator” are universally viewed as a benign example of the US acting as a crucial force for good in the world. The same was true when the US engaged in a massive invasion of Iraq that was under the tight control of another “evil dictator” who allegedly posed a terroristic threat to the world. In both invasions government propaganda pronouncements were widely echoed without question or challenge by media personnel, and media stories and imagery highlighted the suffering of the worthy Ukrainians, while rendering virtually invisible the unwor-

thy Iraqi victims. Yet, by the standards of the post-WWII Geneva Conventions, both invasions involved war crimes by the perpetrators.

The Unworthy Victims of the US Invasion of Iraq in 2003

In the years following the disastrous US assault on Vietnam, government and military personnel concluded that propaganda and media control were imperative if the US was to win its wars and military interventions. Thus the Reagan administration barred reporters from access to the US assault on Grenada in 1983, as did the Bush I administration during the US invasion of Panama, leaving government characterization of these wars unchallenged in mainstream media.

Dating back to elite planning for the post-WWII world, a key part of the US drive for global hegemony was control over the flow of oil out of the Middle East. To this end, among other interventions, the US overthrew the democratically elected Mossadegh regime in Iran in 1953, installing the ruthless regime of the Shah, and in 1990 lured Saddam Hussein into invading Kuwait, which became the pretext for the massive US Gulf War assault on Iraq. During the Gulf War, US reporters were tightly controlled by the military, and largely prevented from reporting on civilian Iraqi casualties. Bolstered by unchallenged government propaganda that included a Hill & Knowlton PR fabrication about Iraqi soldiers removing Kuwaiti infants from their incubators and leaving them on the floor to die, the result was a profoundly sanitized media presentation of a war in which the US demolished Iraq’s water-purification system and electric grid and subjected Iraq to lethal punitive sanctions. The combined US tactics produced hundreds of thousands of Iraqi civilian casualties, including 500,000 children as a consequence of UN sanctions backed by the US and UK. After the fact, as more damaging information began to find its way into mainstream media, popular support for the war declined, and the government’s near totalitarian control of the media was challenged. Consequently, in 2003, the government had an alternative plan for controlling the message that reached the American people.

First, a tightly-coordinated government propaganda bombardment in the weeks and months leading up to the US war was echoed by mass media personnel acting as cheerleaders for the war effort, unquestioningly reporting what administration and military personnel told them.² As occurred during the Gulf War, the television networks employed national security and/or retired military personnel —many of whom had ties to defense contractors invested in the war— as on-air interpreters of war events. The Bush Administration —from the President and Vice-President through high-level State, Defense and National Security leaders—bombarded the media with lies that allegedly justified the American invasion. Two lies were crucial: 1) that Saddam Hussein had weapons of mass destruction (WMDs), including an unaccounted-for “massive stockpile” of biological weapons and an active program to build nuclear weapons, and 2) that Saddam collaborated with Al Qaeda thereby posing a perilous threat of global terrorism.

As [Bush put it](#), in words that were echoed by the other key leaders in his administration, “Facing clear evidence of peril, we cannot wait for the final proof—the smoking gun —that could come in the form of a mushroom cloud” In the same October 2002 speech, Bush also asserted “We know that Iraq and the al-Qaeda terrorist

network share a common enemy—the United States of America. We know that Iraq and al-Qaeda have had high-level contacts that go back a decade.... We've learned that Iraq has trained al-Qaeda members in bomb-making and poisons and deadly gases." Thus, he reasoned, Saddam could share chemical or biological weapons with the terrorist group that had already attacked the United States.

It was powerful messaging by the Administration over the months leading up to the March invasion. As the neoconservatives planned the expansion of their "War on Terror" to attack Iraq, along with their vision for US global domination, the *New York Times* ran a series of front-page articles by reporter Judith Miller. Miller's articles reinforced administration claims by drawing heavily on the "intelligence" of Iraqi defectors like Ahmad Chalabi who, with neoconservative sponsorship, had been campaigning for "regime change" in Iraq. Similarly, the Washington Post was dominated by front page articles echoing administration rhetoric, whereas stories about more skeptical speeches by Senators Kennedy and Byrd were buried deep in the paper. While CIA officials refuted administration claims in independent (non-corporate) media, CIA findings were widely cherry-picked by the administration—notably by VP Dick Cheney—to provide alleged support for its claims.

Not surprisingly American public opinion revealed that a majority of Americans supported removing Saddam from power in the lead up to the war. An October 2002 [CNN/USA/Gallup poll](#) showed 53% supporting a US invasion of Iraq to remove Saddam from power; in fact support for an invasion of Iraq ranged between 53% and 74% in the months since 9/11. Indeed, a January 2003 [poll](#) revealed that a majority of Americans believe Iraq had played a significant role in the 9/11 attacks.

On February 15, 2003, the world's largest antiwar protest in history, involving what the BBC estimated to be between six and ten million people, erupted in 600 cities world-wide, including hundreds of thousands in New York and San Francisco. Yet critical or antiwar voices virtually disappeared from mass media discourse during the lead up to the invasion, even though at the same time independent, progressive and international media were refuting both the WMD and Al Qaeda propaganda themes. In one notable case, the liberal talk-show host, Phil Donahue, included antiwar critics on his MSNBC show, and was subsequently fired by the network.

War Imagery: Drama, US Weaponry, and Unworthy Iraqis

Especially in highly imagistic television coverage, imagery from the war was fixated on massively destructive US weaponry, beginning with the "shock and awe" unleashed as the US bombarded Baghdad on March 20, 2003. The incendiary spectacle was widely observed through TV screens, albeit at a distance that meant viewers would not see the human casualties produced by US weaponry. Indeed, civilian casualties were invisible to American audiences. A website hosted by Vortech displayed some images of Iraqi civilian casualties; Vortech shut it down on March 24 on the grounds that it was "[inappropriate graphic material](#)." Instead of covering the devastating effects on Iraqis and their society, the media concentrate on dramatic stories told by embedded reporters, or the quest to find Saddam Hussein, or events staged by the US to capture desirable imagery for American audiences.

The idea to embed reporters with US ground troops was the brainchild of [Victoria Clark](#), hired by Donald Rumsfeld from her post at the Hill & Knowlton PR firm. Placing reporters with ground units meant they became dependent on the troops for their own safety and American audiences were treated to images of reporters getting trained, wearing gas masks and flak jackets, and images that reflected the war as experienced by US ground soldiers. NPR's [Tom Gjelten gushed](#), "We were offered an irresistible opportunity: free transportation to the front line of war, dramatic pictures, dramatic sounds, great quotes. Who can pass that up?" One academic study of [television war coverage](#) noted: ...all of the American media largely shied away from showing visuals of coalition, Iraqi military, or civilian casualties. Despite advanced technologies offering reporters the chance to transmit the reality of war in real time, reporters chose instead to present a largely bloodless conflict to viewers, even when they did broadcast during firefights.... For American viewers in particular, the portrait of war offered by the networks was a sanitized one free of bloodshed, dissent, and diplomacy but full of exciting weaponry, splashy graphics, and heroic soldiers.

Instead the media were drawn to a range of US-staged events where images reinforced US propaganda. Among others, Vice President Cheney had publicly announced that invading US forces would be "greeted as liberators," whereas ample evidence has revealed the opposite to be true for most Iraqis. US troops had destroyed dozens of Saddam Hussein statues, but in April 2003, gathering near an outsized statue of Saddam in Firdos Square, the soldiers noticed a handful of Iraqis, at least one of whose family members had been executed by Saddam and wanted the statue pulled down. They also noticed a large number of journalists and cameras present. So with a handful of Iraqis cheering and waving flags provided for them by the Americans, US forces used a M-88 vehicle to pull down the huge statue, producing what the [Guardian](#) would later call "the abiding image of the war" in 2003. Two hours of non-stop coverage of the event was transmitted around the world that night, and between 11 AM and 8 PM the next day, the cable news networks had a field day. Fox News aired the images every 4.4 minutes, and CNN did the same every 7.5 minutes. CNN's Wolf Blitzer exclaimed that the image "sums up the day, and in many ways, the war itself."

Other staged or heavily distorted dramatic events included President Bush being air-lifted onto the returning US aircraft carrier Abraham Lincoln off the coast of San Diego. On May 1, 2003, Bush strutted out to be viewed among the troops, wearing an improbable flight suit; behind him a large banner proclaimed "Mission Accomplished." The improbable event was widely mocked on *The Daily Show* and other late night TV shows. Other dramatic stories included Secretary of State Colin Powell's major address before the UN Security Council, universally greeted by the US mass media as the clinching proof of WMDs. Independent media and former intelligence officials demonstrated how the misleading images failed to reveal any WMD threat. Also, the long US search for Saddam Hussein, which after a dozen unsuccessful raids, ended with him being captured while hiding in a well, leading to his later execution. One widely-hyped drama, the alleged rescue of "POW" Private Jessica Lynch, was fed to reporters by [Combat Camera](#), a Pentagon operation that

provided 800 photos and 25 video clips a day to the media. In its May 15 exposé, [The Guardian](#) revealed how the “icon of the war” story was “one of the most stunning pieces of news management yet conceived.”

As the invasion turned into a long and highly contested occupation by the US, American and Iraqi casualties mounted up, and, of course, as no WMDs were discovered, the American public soured on the war. Twenty years later, mainstream media from the *New York Times* to NPR acknowledged the exorbitant human and financial costs of the war and the falsity of administration claims, but they labored to put the best face on Bush administration ‘mistakes.’ The main [Times](#) retrospective puzzled that “20 Years On, a Question Lingers about Iraq: Why Did the US Invade?” The paper pointed to “processes and rationales so convoluted that even the people involved might not know exactly how they happened.” Perhaps none of the revisionism is as striking as the rewriting of the US assault on the city of Fallujah in 2004, largely remembered ten years later as a place where US soldiers made great sacrifices. As correspondent Terry Moran [explained](#), “More than 100 Marines gave their lives to pacify the city.” Yet as Mike Marqusee reported in the [Guardian](#): The assault was preceded by eight weeks aerial bombardment. US troops cut off the city’s water, power and food supplies, condemned as a violation of the Geneva Convention by a UN special rapporteur, who accused occupying forces of ‘using hunger and deprivation as a weapon of war against a civilian population. Two-thirds of the city’s 300,000 residents fled, many to squatters’ camps without basic facilities.

As if this revisionism wasn’t enough, the U.S. Navy has recently [announced](#) that it will name a new amphibious assault ship *Fallujah*, “to memorialize the Marines, Soldiers, and coalition partners that fought valiantly and those that sacrificed their lives during both battles of Fallujah.”

The Ukrainians: Worthy of Endless Coverage

With the Ukrainian-Russian war currently in its second year, US mass media coverage has continued unabated, largely with daily reports on the war. The Ukraine had been subjected to invasion, and sometimes occupation, by pre-Soviet Russians, the Soviet Union, and Nazi Germany. Contemporary Russian forces annexed Crimea and supported pro-Russian separatists in the Donbas area after the 2014 Euromaidan uprisings. On February 24, 2022, the Russian army began the full-scale invasion of Ukraine. In response, the West, led by the United States, imposed a new round of sanctions on Russia and began to provide enormous financial and military support to help Ukraine defend against the invasion. To date, the US has contributed over \$75 billion in aid to Ukraine, 61% of which is military aid in the form of weaponry, equipment, training and “security assistance”; 34% of which is financial assistance, and 5% “humanitarian” assistance.

I juxtapose two competing interpretive stories about the war in Ukraine — one dominates reporting in the American media, while the other is virtually invisible in the American media. The latter story points to actions by the United States as part of its on-going quest to remain a dominant global hegemon. The former faithfully follow what the [State Department](#) stated in justifying support for Ukraine: “The United States, our allies, and our partners worldwide are united in support of Ukraine in

response to Russia’s premeditated, *unprovoked*, and unjustified war against Ukraine. We have not forgotten Russia’s earlier aggression in eastern Ukraine and occupation following its unlawful seizure of Crimea in 2014 [emphasis added].”

Especially when viewed in the context of Russian history, Putin certainly could legitimately reason that two episodes *were* threatening provocations by the West. The first of these was the decision made by the US and NATO to allow the former Warsaw Pact nations, or former Soviet Union republics, to join the North Atlantic Treaty Organization, a Cold War throwback led by the US to blunt any perceived Soviet threat to the West. In the aftermath of the Soviet Union’s dissolution in 1991 and the start of “free-market” based “shock therapy” in former Soviet states, US officials debated whether to grant membership in NATO to Eastern European nations. As these discussions proceeded, George Kennan, formerly the leading voice for the Cold War “containment” policy, wrote an op-ed in the *New York Times*, titled “[A Fatal Error](#).” Noting that by 1996, it appeared that the decision to admit nations into NATO “up to the Russian border” had been made, Kennan wrote: ...expanding NATO would be the most fateful error of American policy in the entire post-cold-war era. Such a decision may be expected to inflame the nationalistic, anti-Western and militaristic tendencies in Russian opinion; to have an adverse effect on the development of Russian democracy; to restore the atmosphere of the cold war to East-West relations, and to impel Russian foreign policy in directions decidedly not to our liking.... Russians are little impressed with American assurances that it reflects no hostile intentions. They would see their prestige (always uppermost in the Russian mind) and their security interests as adversely affected.

Innumerable high US officials — Madeleine Albright, Strobe Talbot, and Robert Gates — have acknowledged the truth of Kennan’s warning. [Gates described](#) the Bush II effort to bring Georgia and Ukraine into NATO as “truly overreaching” and “recklessly ignoring what the Russians considered their own vital national interests.” Beginning in 1999, twelve former Warsaw Pact nations or former Soviet republics sought and won membership in NATO. In response to the Russian invasion, long-neutral Finland joined NATO on April 4, 2023, producing an additional 841 miles of NATO members bordering Russia.

The other provocation revolved around the so-called “Euromaidan Revolution” of 2013–4 that drove Ukraine President Viktor Yanukovich from power.³ Although democratically elected, Viktor Yanukovich’s presidency was becoming increasingly corrupt and autocratic, and Ukraine’s economy was falling behind EU states. Heavily dependent on Russian natural gas, Yanukovich allowed the Russian Black Sea fleet to use Crimea as a base even as he pursued a free-trade agreement with the EU, one that came with austerity demands required by IMF loans. Putin offered Ukraine a no-strings attached loan equal to the IMF’s, while also threatening to block the flow of Russian gas. Yanukovich reneged on the EU deal, which produced the initial citizens’ uprising in the Maidan (Kyiv’s Independence Square). Yanukovich responded with a brutal crackdown that violently scattered the protesters and followed up with new repressive anti-protest laws.

The government’s violence drew wider numbers into the protests which, in turn, became more violent themselves. The key force behind the protest violence

was Ukraine's long-standing far right—the Svoboda Party, initially founded as the “Social-National Party of Ukraine (a hint at its Nazi sympathies) and the “Right Sector” that traces back to genocidal Nazi collaborators. As the crisis escalated, Yanukovich and opposition parties agreed to scale back presidential powers and schedule an election—an agreement that enraged the increasingly militant street movement. Yanukovich fled Kyiv and Parliament voted to strip him of his presidency, winning the praise of the US ambassador.

The US saw in the protest movement an opportunity to reverse the abandoned EU agreement. Senators John McCain and Chris Murphy stood in Kyiv's Square, aside Svoboda's fascist leader, announcing their support to the protesters. US assistant secretary of state in the Obama administration, Victoria Nuland, maneuvered behind the scenes to successfully push the Americans' favorite candidate to lead the new government as Prime Minister. Once in office, he signed the original EU deal solidifying Ukraine's move toward integration with Europe. Meanwhile the winner of the 2014 election, the extremely wealthy Petro Poroshenko took office; his interior minister incorporated the neo-Nazi militia, Azov Regiment, into Ukraine's National Guard; Ukraine's politics shifted to the right. Little changed once Volodymyr Zelensky, an “outsider” candidate was resoundingly elected in 2019.

As noted by Ted Galen Carpenter's CATO commentary, both the Obama administration and most of the US mass media portrayed the Euromaidan Revolution as a “spontaneous, popular uprising against a corrupt and brutal government,” yet [Carpenter observed](#), “The extent of the Obama administration's meddling in Ukraine's politics was breathtaking.” As Branko [Marcetic](#) put it in *Jacobin*, “There is no doubt US officials backed and exploited Euromaidan for their own ends.... Western involvement helped bring the country to this crisis.”

Furthermore peace talks between Ukrainian and Russian officials in the first month after the invasion showed, at a lower diplomatic level, the potential shape of a peace agreement. According to the sketched out 15-point agreement Ukraine would embrace neutrality and forego joining NATO, Russia would withdraw from all but Crimea and the Donbas region of Ukraine, the future of which would be determined by the self-determination of the people in those regions, and the future security of Ukraine would be guaranteed by an outside group of countries, although Ukraine would not allow foreign military bases in its territory.

On April 9, 2022, the UK's Boris Johnson visited Zelensky to assure him of British backing for however long it took to ensure Ukrainian independence from Russia. [Johnson publicly declared](#), “I made clear today that the United Kingdom stands unwaveringly with them in this ongoing fight, and we are in it for the long run. We are stepping up our own military and economic support and convening a global alliance to bring this tragedy to an end, and ensure Ukraine survives and thrives as a free and sovereign nation.” Two weeks later, US Defense Secretary [Lloyd Austin declared](#), “We want to see Russia weakened to the degree that it can't do the kinds of things that it has done in invading Ukraine.” As of April 14, 2022, the US had already provided Ukraine with \$2.6 billion in security aid, including a wide range of weaponry. As military support from the US, EU, Britain and others grew exponentially, along with casualties on both sides, positions hardened and Ukraine proceeded to apply for

NATO membership while Russia indicated no further interest in the bilateral negotiations with Ukraine.

It should be noted that, in most cases, this “illegitimate” story views the Russian invasion as an aggressive violation of Ukrainian sovereignty, resulting in major destruction of Ukrainian lives and infrastructure. As such it can be compared to the US invasion of Iraq, albeit on a smaller scale than the long-term US assault on Iraq from 1991 to 2011. But it also maintains that the US clearly provided Putin with provocations that reflect the hegemonic or imperial objectives of US foreign policy. The competing interpretations revolve around the motives of Putin and Russia, and the United States. The story of the war told across the board in the US corporate media omits the US provocation perspective as well as the relevance of US imperial ambitions—these are either ignored as non-existent or irrelevant. In the absence of these perspectives, speculation focused entirely on the motives of Putin—taking at face value his grandiose rhetoric, comparing him to Hitler or [dismissing him](#) as a “madman” or a “psychopath.”

For example, a Lexis-Nexis search revealed that the *New York Times* included the phrase “unprovoked invasion,” 327 times between February 21, 2022, and April 2023—138 occurred in February and March of 2022. All but three of the references applied to the Russian invasion of Ukraine. Of course, more than a few of these were uttered by President Biden, who referred to the “brutal and unprovoked invasion” by Russia, or by other US or European leaders. On March 4, 2022, Columnist Fareed Zakaria referred to it as an “utterly unprovoked, unjustified, immoral invasion,” and *Times* op-ed columnists Thomas Friedman and Charles Blow referred to the “unprovoked invasion.” BP and Starbucks executives did the same in the paper of record, although the *Times* pointed out that many US food and fast-food companies remained curiously silent while carrying on their businesses in Russia. Even late-night host Jimmy Kimmel got in on the act with a condemnation of the “unprovoked invasion.” A pre-war newsletter column by David Leonhardt anticipated Russia's “unprovoked ground invasion,” and Reagan's Secretary of State James Baker chimed in similarly in a guest editorial.

Other “unprovoked invasion” mentions were simply included in articles focusing on other matters related to Russia. For example, an article about the WNBA basketball player Brittany Griner referred to the “unprovoked Russian invasion.” An article in December 2022 looked back on a year seen as “the Beginning of a Green Transition,” but went on to note that the coming year was likely to be one of a European energy crisis, thanks to Russia's “unprovoked invasion.”

Finally, in an editorial that reveals the paper's predictable amnesia, the *Times* offered the opinion on February 24, 2022 that “an unprovoked invasion of a sovereign state in the 21st Century is madness.”

In sum, it is simply a given truth, repeated again and again in the paper of record, that Russia's invasion was unprovoked. One can search in vain for any *Times* article about the claim of US/NATO provocations, with one or two exceptions that dismiss those who raise such a possibility. Instead, the paper goes on at some length about Russian “propaganda,” which of course exists. But the repetition of the one-

themed characterization of an enemy state couldn't possibly be viewed as a form of propaganda. It's simply the truth, end of story.

Indeed, not only were the "illegitimate" challenges to the propaganda ignored by the mass media, but anyone who raised critiques of US policy was likely to be branded a Putin apologist or worse. Such was the case with the group of progressive members of Congress who sent a letter to the White House calling on the Biden administration to pursue diplomacy with Russia. Even though the letter took pains to applaud the Biden administrations' military support for Ukraine, once it became public, the group endured a tidal wave of attacks from across the mainstream political spectrum. The letter was retracted one day later, with most signers scrambling to distance themselves from the letter. To ensure a discourse of total support, government and private sector officials have gone to great lengths to ensure that critical information is kept out of public discourse. Thus the EU banned the Russian television channel, RT, and a long list of US providers—Microsoft, Meta, YouTube, TikTok, Twitter, Google, Apple, DirecTV and Spotify—removed RT content or access.

Furthermore, the mass media have essentially ignored the existence of the powerful influence of the far-right in Ukrainian politics. In the case of the neo-Nazi Azov Battalion deployed against the Russians, the *New York Times* seems to have a double standard depending on whether the Azov Battalion is fighting the Russians or not. In a 2019 story about a white supremacist charged with killing 49 people in New Zealand, the *Times* noted that his flak jacket bore the symbol "commonly used by the Azov Battalion, a Ukrainian neo-Nazi paramilitary organization." By contrast, in a [war report](#) on October 2022, the *Times* noted that "Commanders of Ukraine's celebrated Azov Battalion have held an emotional reunion with their families in Turkey [emphasis added]." As noted by Ukrainian sociologist [Volodymyr Ishchenko](#) of the Institute for East European Studies, most Ukrainian political parties are "electoral machines" for "specific patron-clientele networks," whereas the radical nationalist [Rightist] parties, "by contrast have ideology, they have motivated activists, and at this moment, they are probably the only parties in the real sense of the word 'party.' They are the most organized, the most mobilized parts of the civil society, with the strongest street mobilization."

And so, the corporate media once again fell into line with the US government's official claims about the invasion and US actions: as a benign effort to protect Ukraine from a "premeditation, unprovoked, and unjustified" invasion. From the start, with reporters free to seek out their own stories, media reports repeatedly documented the widespread destruction caused by the Russians through missile, tank, and infantry attacks, typically with gripping imagery. Early on, as Russian troops were advancing towards Kyiv stories speculated about the Russian goal of absorbing all of Ukraine into the Russian orbit. As the US began to ship military equipment to Ukraine, reporters demanded to know why the US was "[holding back](#)" from striking out directly at Russia.

As the war progressed, war imagery showing the destruction in Ukraine became a daily event. A sampling follows:⁴

- Desperate refugees running toward an arriving train
- A man weeping after his family escaped on a train

- A bloodied school teacher in the doorway of her school
- A large crowd of Ukrainians under a partially destroyed bridge, waiting to escape across the river
- Children sleeping in an underground subway station
- A firefighter in a destroyed house
- A wounded pregnant woman outside the bombed maternity hospital
- The body of a 6-year-old girl in a hospital
- A Ukrainian soldier carrying a baby across a destroyed bridge
- A weeping woman with two girls who had fled to Moldova
- Ukrainian soldiers taking cover from an artillery shelling
- The body of a Russian soldier in the snow next to a destroyed armored vehicle
- A mother and boyfriend racing her wounded 18-month old to the hospital
- Repeated images of multistory apartment buildings destroyed by missiles
- A woman weeping inside the destroyed remnants of her home
- A man covered with bleeding wounds after a missile attack
- A destroyed gate next to graffiti saying "Welcome to Hell"
- A woman crying over the bodies of her dead son and grandson
- A long line of empty graves prepared for Ukrainian soldiers to come
- Ukrainian soldiers cooking food in kitchen bunker
- Multiple images of Ukrainians searching for bodies under destroyed apartment buildings
- Body bags of Ukrainians recovered from apartment ruins
- A woman who had been lying dead in a doorway for two days
- Multiple images of grieving survivors at gravesides and funerals
- Ukrainian Bodies being exhumed from mass graves
- Crowds of people in a long line for free bread handouts
- Debris of a destroyed church
- 2 men salvaging a refrigerator for a destroyed home
- A six-year-old girl and a young man learning to walk with a prosthetic leg after a Russian shelling
- Ukrainian soldiers holding a captive they accused of spying for the Russians
- A bombed-out school, and a partially destroyed university classroom
- An entire row of destroyed apartment high rises and houses in Kyiv suburb
- Piled-up ruins of destroyed automobiles.
- A hand protruding from a mass grave
- A dog lying near the body of a retired teacher.

Clearly the destruction of civilian life, and civilians, in the Ukraine has been heavily documented by the mass media—in stark contrast to media coverage of the US invasion of Iraq.

Estimated totals of casualties on both sides of the war have varied widely, reflecting their sources, but civilian deaths in the Ukraine have minimally been in the tens of thousands, while estimates for both Ukrainian and Russian soldiers' deaths range far higher, again, depending on who is doing the estimating.

As the war began to take on the appearance of a bloody stalemate, speculation has increased about the potential for a nuclear war, as both Putin and officials in the US have warned of nuclear escalation and its dangers. Not surprisingly antiwar sentiment has grown in the US and parts of Europe. On March 18, 2023, an antiwar rally and march outside the White House was called by a coalition of more than 200 peace and anti-militarism groups on the 20th anniversary of the Iraq invasion. Although an estimated 2-3000 protested, [none of the national media](#)—including the local *Washington Post*—viewed the protest as remotely newsworthy.

Given the corporate media's complete subservience to US government propaganda, while the public is bombarded by gripping imagery of the human and physical costs of the Russian invasion, it is understandable that people across much of the political spectrum have had their sympathies aroused for the Ukraine and their antipathies focused on Putin and the Russian government. Yet as the war grinds on and people are mindful of the costs of the war vs. other unmet domestic needs, there has been some [softening of support](#) for US policy. Similarly, the complete subservience of mass media to government propaganda during the US invasion of Iraq coupled with the absence of gripping images of Iraqi victims made for initial support for that war—although it, too, faded over time.

What is crucially lost in both of these horrific events is anything that might suggest to the American public that they have long been fed lies about the United States record and objectives in the rest of the world. As journalist [John Pilger](#) put it, "An accounting of the sheer scale and continuity and consequences of American imperialism is our elite's most enduring taboo."

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Endnotes

1 Edward S. Herman and Noam Chomsky, *Manufacturing Consent: The Political Economy of Mass Media* (New York, Pantheon, 2002).

2 For audio-visual documentation (and refutation) of the government's propaganda see the video "[Uncovered: the War on Iraq](#)." For media coverage leading up to the war see Bill Moyers' video, "[Buying the War](#)."

3 I draw on two sources in elaborating these events: the "free market" oriented CATO Institute and the democratic socialist journal Jacobin.

4 Among others, both [CNN](#) and the [New York Times](#) have gathered photographs from the war online.

China's BRI: Toward a Hybrid International Order with Socialist Characteristics?

GARY OLSON

This year marks the 10th anniversary of President Xi Jinping's launch of China's flagship, One Belt One Road (OBOR), later referred to as the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). Echoing the historic Silk Road, the ancient trade network of Eurasia that connected the East and West, BRI is the most ambitious and expensive infrastructure plan in world history. Writing about BRI's future, the British Economist once worried that "All roads lead to Beijing."

In September 2013, on a visit to Nazarbayev University, Kazakhstan, President Xi advocated the establishment of a "Silk Road Economic Belt." A month later, addressing the Indonesian parliament, he proposed a "Maritime Silk Road of the 20th Century". The trans-continental corridor links China with Southeast Asia, South Asia, Russia, and Europe by land. The new sea trade route connects Chinese coast regions with southeast and south Asia, the South Pacific, the Middle East, and Eastern Africa, all the way to Europe.

BRI was later extended to include Latin America and initiatives to Polar regions through the "Silk Road on Ice" in the Arctic, a Digital Silk Road, and another to outer space via the Space Information Corridor. Lastly, special mention should be made of The Green Silk Road, the scope of which includes reducing climate emissions, reducing pollution, and protecting biodiversity. This is part of China's prioritizing sustainable development under the United Nations' 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. In sum, the BRI seeks to promote economic globalization, multipolarity, poverty reduction, livelihood improvement, cultural diversification, and environmental protection.

The BRI is China's signature foreign policy effort, in Xi's words, to help achieve a "community of common destiny" which encompasses a "commonality of shared interests" as it "complements other economies" on the way to providing "one home for man." Tang Qifang, a scholar at the China Institute of International Studies, describes BRI as "The concept of a community of common destiny transcending all sorts of differences in human society and targets the greatest possible benefits for all." This embodies, "The Chinese aspiration to share power and development with the world." (When Noam Chomsky was asked what he thought about the China-proposed "human community with a shared future," he replied, "That's exactly what we need.")

And, Xi has repeatedly stressed that the nation's destiny is "interwoven with that of another dialogue rather than confrontation, partnerships instead of alliances should be the pursuit of all nations in a win-win project." In keeping with this sentiment, China will transfer its competitive productive capacity as its industries possess a competitive edge.

In a 2018 speech, Xi said,

To respond to the call of the times, China is ready to jointly promote the Belt and Road Initiative with partners. We hope to create new drivers to power common development through this new platform of international cooperation; and we hope to turn it into a road of peace, prosperity, openness, green development, and innovation. And a road brings together different civilizations.²

On numerous occasions, Xi has stressed that “We Chinese love peace. No matter how strong it may become China will never seek hegemony or expansion. It will never inflict its past suffering on any nation.”

It's not lost on the peoples of Africa, Asia, and Latin America that when colonizers built infrastructure it facilitated outward-bound routes whereas the Chinese infrastructure serves internal connections within the continent. W. Gyude Moore, former Minister for Public Works in Liberia, didn't mince words when he said, “China has built more infrastructure in Africa than the West did in centuries.”³

As of January 2023, 152 countries and 32 international organizations had signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) and this includes 75% of the world's population and half of the world's GDP. Some economic forecasts predict that by 2027, BRI's worldwide projects will number 2,600 valued at \$3.7 trillion.

Further, data show that the cumulative value of trade in goods between China and countries along the BRI routes reached nearly \$11 trillion between 2013 and 2021, with a two-way investment reaching more than \$230 billion.

According to a 2022 World Bank forecast, if only the BRI transportation infrastructure projects are eventually carried out, by 2030, the BRI will generate \$1.6 trillion in revenues for the globe or 1.3 percent of global GDP. And up to 90 percent of the revenues will go to the partnering countries.⁴

Thousands of projects (3,000 in Africa, alone), initially focused on roads, ports, railways, pipelines, and power stations. More recently, there are cross-border fiber optic cables, space networks, schools, hospitals, solar panels, health care, and financial services. Projects range from the Sudanese Railways Authority receiving a first installment of 21 locomotives which will significantly improve rail capacity and 620 Lifan taxi cars in Montevideo, Uruguay to the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor. At a cost of \$95.5 billion, it involves a port, highways, an airport, fiber optic cables, railways, and power plants. Many of the latter are running on solar, hydro, and wind power.

In June 2023, Egypt and China announced a BRI investment deal worth more than \$8 billion for the Suez Canal Zone which will allow Chinese companies access to African and European markets while taking advantage of the canal's strategic position. Another notable project, the Jakarta-Bandung high-speed rail in Indonesia at a cost between \$6–8 billion encountered logistical problems after being scheduled to begin service in July 2023. The Chinese would be the first to acknowledge that BRI is not a miracle worker, success is not invariably guaranteed and although it originated in China, BRI belongs to all the members.

Recent BRI projects in Latin America include the \$1.52 billion Fourth Bridge over the Panama Canal and the \$5 billion Bogota metro line 1 in Colombia. In early June

2023 (during official visits to Beijing, Honduran President Xiomara Castro expressed interest in joining BRI and signed 17 trade agreements with China and Argentina agreed to projects involving infrastructure, energy, economy, and trade. Other projects are underway in Chile, Guyana, and Trinidad and Tobago. At the end of 2021, Chinese investments in Latin America exceeded \$450 billion. It should be noted that the U.S. has expressed its pique over BRI projects, especially in Panama, and has warned Latin America about Chinese BRI deals that were “too good to be true.”

Clearly, Latin America will not be amenable if China exhibits neo-imperial behavior and begins contradicting Xi's pledge of “providing harmony, security, and prosperity to both China and its neighbors” and seeks to impose its influence. Seemingly recognizing this, China's Foreign Minister Wang Yi has taken pains to emphasize that BRI “should not be viewed through the outdated Cold War mentality.”⁵

Addressing and expanding this concern, Peng Guangqun, a retired major general and advisor to the Chinese National Security Commission, writes that: “BRI does not limit the nature of a given country's political system, is not underline by ideology, does not create tiny circles of friends, does not set up trade protectionism, does not set up an economic blockade, does not exercise control of other countries' economic lifelines or change other countries' political systems.”⁶

Finally, more than 700 million of the globe's extremely poor people live along the BRI, and addressing the wealth disparity of the international order imposed on the Global South is a BRI priority. China, with a population of 1.4 billion, is now free of extreme poverty after it was eradicated for 850 million people. Chinese Foreign Minister Qin Gang has said that the Belt and Road Initiative had accomplished this for 40 million people. This number accords with a World Bank study from four years ago that concluded BRI could lift 32 million out of moderate poverty and 7.6 out of extreme poverty.

Will BRI flounder and fizzle out? Back in 2017, UN Secretary General Antonio Guterres praised BRI's “immense potential,” lauded it for having “sustainable development as the overarching objective” and pledged the “United Nations system stands ready to travel this road with you.”⁷ In 2022, China's engagement through financial investment and contractual cooperation in 147 countries was US \$67–8 billion on over 200 deals. This was about the same as in 2021 and for 2023, and more BRI engagement is expected because strict COVID restrictions were lifted.

From a report issued by Ernst & Young, we know that Chinese trade with BRI countries in Q1 of this year was US \$31.66 billion, an increase of 9.2%. It should be mentioned that there is no budget line for BRI in the Chinese government's budget, rather, it remains a platform for launching a multitude of projects from vision to reality. In the future, we should expect fewer bilateral arrangements and more emphasis on bringing other countries into a quasi-governance structure, something on the order of the BRI steering committee. And also, more collaboration with the UN acting as an umbrella-type body.⁸

In 2017, the BRI was written into the Chinese Communist Party's Constitution as an indicator of its importance. Australian Professor Jane Colley, who has studied BRI from its inception, believes “They are absolutely still advancing it” and as far as outside pressure, she adds that, “Any idea of containing them or forcing countries to pick a

side—it's a very risky game to play."⁹ And after a comprehensive look at BRI, the mainstream publication *Euromoney*, concedes that "The BRI is neither dead nor dying but is quietly mutating into something much larger and—whisper it—perhaps better."¹⁰

Will the BRI prove to be a platform that offers an alternative to the capitalist world order? The most comprehensive and objective attempt at predicting what BRI will resemble in 2035 contains various scenarios. The most optimistic, the "international BRI," assumes the world will have entered a new phase of globalization. This world will be less Chinese, although the renminbi (RMB) will be widely accepted as a reserve currency.

This BRI will incorporate "Chinese values," but this stage will be neither Western nor Chinese nor will it lead to China as the new hegemonic state. There will be increased cooperation, the option China committed to at the 75th UN General Assembly.¹¹ In short, it will be a "thoroughly hybrid paradigm of global cooperation."¹² One factor, that might tend to mitigate that optimistic rendering is that the amount of finance available for BRI projects might be constrained by the need to focus on domestic economic priorities.

U.S Opposition to BRI

In 2011, two years before President Xi unveiled BRI, Yan Xuetang penned an opinion piece in *The New York Times*, titled "How China Can Defeat America."

Yan, one of China's foremost international relations scholars and Dean of the Institute of International Relations at Tsinghua University in Beijing, offered his explanation for China's eventual rise and the slow decline of the United States. By interrogating the particulars of national leadership in China's past, Yan concluded that morality might well play a key role in the competition between the two great powers.

Yan identifies himself as a political realist, a school that assumes international politics is a zero-sum game. But unlike most scholars in this field, Yan argued that "morally informed authority" can play a key role in shaping international competition between China and the United States. This "humane authority, creates a desirable model at home that inspires people abroad" and in the international competition between the two great powers, this will win hearts and minds and "separate the winners from the losers."¹³ One gets the sense that Yan is implicitly implying that the U.S. will fail in this competition but he's also challenging his own government to take advantage of this opportunity.

Eight years later, in his 2019 groundbreaking book "Leadership and the Rise of Great Powers," Yan wrote that "moral actions help a rising power to establish credibility." Yan never abjures the existence of power hierarchies, and that anarchy prevails in relations among nations. However, morally informed leadership can determine the outcome of the competition—without resorting to military confrontation. This moral realism "with Chinese characteristics" can be described as a form of enlightened self-interest.

This "morally informed leadership... the side that wins the most international support will win the competition." This should be a prime consideration in conducting foreign policy gains and "enables its leadership to become favorable to the majority of UN members."

When the BRI was first announced by China in 2013, it did not immediately set off alarm bells in Washington. But later, a study done for the U.S. Council on Foreign Relations, an organization that sets the American empire's imperial agenda, warned that "The BRI is here to stay and poses significant risks to U.S. economic and political interests and to longer-term security implications."¹⁴

After the BRI had been in existence for seven years, it was characterized as China's "means of weaponizing globalization to create commercial and political order centered around dependence on China."¹⁵ Both of these succinct summations reveal that the U.S. view of the BRI cannot be divorced from how U.S. oligarchs and the military-industrial complex perceive China more generally and here we return to the aforementioned realist school of international relations.

American political scientist Hans Morgenthau's book *Politics Among Nations*, first published in 1948, became the centerpiece of U.S. foreign policy for at least four decades. It's fair to say that Morgenthau was the father of the realist school, and his book was adopted as the primary text in colleges and universities across the country. My undergraduate political science professor had been one of Morgenthau's graduate students at the University of Chicago and my copy of *Politics Among Nations* was heavily underlined in preparation for class discussion and exams.

In brief, the political realist assumes that all people are by "nature" greedy, aggressive, and fiercely competitive. Morgenthau counseled that "Politics is governed by objective laws that have their roots in human nature."¹⁶ Further, "The struggle for power is universal in time and space and is an unavoidable fact of experience." As such, the realist concludes that states, the actors on the international stage, must focus on power. No universal morality exists, and power politics is amoral.

At the time his book was published, the outcome of the Chinese Revolution was still a year away but, in an essay, written in the 1960s, Morgenthau predicted that "China may well in the long run carry the gravest implications for the rest of the world." Given this likelihood, he advised that the U.S. strategy should be to establish an island chain running from Japan down to the Philippines so that one power could not attain a hegemonic position in Asia.¹⁷ It should be noted that prudence was a key concept in Morgenthau's theory and the wise leader should be extremely careful in determining the national interest. It was on that basis that he was an early and active opponent of the Vietnam War. Whether Morgenthau would find common cause with those willing to go to war over Taiwan remains an open question.

John Mearsheimer, a University of Chicago political science professor and arguably the most influential realist today, asserts that "The ultimate goal of every great power is to maximize its share of world power and eventually to dominate the system."¹⁸ In terms of geopolitics, "The U.S. will have no choice but to adopt a realist policy, simply because it must prevent China from becoming a regional hegemon in Asia." Further, he explains: The U.S. does not tolerate peer competitors. As it demonstrated in the 20th century, it is determined to remain the world's only regional hegemon. Therefore, the U.S. can be expected to go to great lengths to contain China and ultimately weaken it to the point where it is no longer capable of ruling the roost in Asia. In essence, the U.S. is likely to behave towards China much the way it behaved towards the Soviet Union during the Cold War.¹⁹

A contemporary and highly influential iteration of the realist school is defense analyst Elsbridge Colby's *Strategy of Denial: American Defense In An Age of Great Power Conflict*.²⁰ Colby, grandson of former CIA Director William Colby, was the primary architect of the Pentagon's National Defense Strategy. Colby's effort is the best example I know of that lays out, chapter and verse, how the U.S. foreign policy elite is preparing for possible limited war with China and if necessary, nuclear war. Reaction from other realist strategies is typified by Robert Kaplan's book cover blurb in which he gushes that Colby "reaches a level of theoretical mastery akin to Hans Morgenthau's *Politics Among Nations*."

To maintain U.S. global domination, Colby states the following about China: We are facing a peer superpower—a generational challenger...China's first step is a hegemonic position over Asia...then from that position, they will be able to gain global predominance from which China will be able to essentially hold sway or influence over the entire world, including, of course, Europe, but also the United States.

To prevent this outcome: Requires that we ruthlessly focus, and that take controversial and aggressive steps to ready ourselves now to avoid worse outcomes later. The problem is that we have not been doing nearly enough of these things. On our current course, we are courting disaster.

And further, if all else fails, "If China is willing to use nuclear weapons and the United States is not, Beijing will dominate over whatever interests are at stake—whether Taiwan's fate, that of another U.S. ally or free American access to Asia more generally." And in a dire warning, Colby asserts that "If China succeeds, we can forget about housing, food, savings, affording college for our kids and other domestic needs. The end of ordinary citizens' property will be here. China would make American society worse off and more susceptible to intense disputes over a stagnant economic pie."

Prudence was a key concept in Morgenthau's theory and the wise leader should be careful in circumscribing the "national interest." It was on that basis that Morgenthau was an early and active opponent of the Vietnam War which he felt lay outside U.S. national interest.

Given the preceding, I sense that U.S. realists view BRI as a vast and growing phalanx of Trojan Horses out of which will emerge the means to challenge Washington's unipolar position. A system that features peaceful development and the promise of "common prosperity" can't be accommodated within the realist school. As Mearsheimer asserts, irrespective of ideology, "The ultimate goal of every great power is to maximize its share of world power and eventually dominate the globe."

The BRI is seen as part of a zero-sum game in which Washington's unipolar world dominance will be eliminated along with a "rules-based international order." Speaking on the CBS program "60 Minutes" (May 2, 2021), U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken said, "Our purpose is...to uphold this rules-based order that China is posing a challenge to. Anyone who poses a challenge to that order, we're going to stand up and defend it." In truth, this order is one which the United States imposed on the world to perpetuate its hegemony. This elusive set of rules, a copy of which ordinary Americans have yet to see, has been thoroughly dissected by Kim Peterson

who notes "It is a given that the rules-based order is an American linguistic instrument designed to preserve it as a global hegemon."²¹

BRI notions of win-win outcomes and a common destiny for mankind simply can't be accommodated in the mindset of the realist practitioners within the U.S. national security state. They only see it as a geopolitical tool, wielded by China, which CIA Director William Burns claims, is the "most important geopolitical threat" facing the United States and if not stopped will eventually challenge American global hegemony.

Given the preceding, it's unwarranted to surmise that a decade of BRI's positive contributions to national development and the promise of more to come, is even viewed as more of a threat to U.S. monopoly capital's interests than China's rapidly growing military preparedness. That is, BRI is a type of normative power that might allow for the creation of a new international order with multilateral institutions that replace the existing ones without engaging in military conflict with the United States, thus "killing two birds with one stone." For the realist, intent on defending the U.S. empire: It goes without saying that this counter-hegemonic geopolitical endeavor is much more threatening to the United States than the geo-strategic actorness of China than the territorial empire which is mainly limited to military actions in China's maritime vicinity.²²

This is because BRI's projects in the Global South stand in sharp relief to their collective memory of the American empire's history of brutal exploitation at the expense of others, of military intervention, giving covert support to opposition groups, stealing natural resources, regime change, CIA coups, assassinations and, of course, the prolongation of structural violence. And even after achieving independence, sometimes after years of liberation struggles, the only development option available has been the capitalist one with its mandated austerity measures that further hastened widespread misery.

The U.S. and its European vassals cannot compete in terms of scale, financing, or political will and therefore have nothing to offer but more of the same. Biden's "Build Back Better" and the EU's "Global Gateway" are rudderless and lack any domestic support. BRI has no serious competitors. Predatory capitalism is in deep trouble and the window of opportunity to act is closing. As such, the Pentagon may try to sabotage BRI by other means, including provoking China into a military confrontation, possibly in the South China Sea, with all the risks of confrontation between two nuclear powers.²³

Earlier this year, Air Force General Mike "unrepentant lethality" Minihan predicted a war with China within the next two years. In a memo to those under his command, he stressed preparing "to fight and win inside the first island range, running through Japan, Taiwan, and the Philippines. And in a speech last September for a 16,000-member aerospace convention, Gen. Minihan declared "Lethality matters most. When you kill your enemy, every part of life is better. Your food tastes better. Your marriage is stronger."²⁴ It's not clear to what degree Minihan is an outlier but the Pentagon may try to indirectly sabotage BRI by other means.

This requires fostering public fears and paranoia about China and that explains why the mass media machine's demonization of China is picking up speed. It seems

to be working: In a March 20–26, 2023, Pew Research Poll, a large majority (84%) of adult Americans now hold a negative view of China and only 14% a positive view, the lowest share ever recorded.²⁵ And 4 in 10 describe China as “an enemy of the United States,” up 13 points since last year and a majority say the U.S. and China cannot work together to solve international problems. 75% of young Americans (18–25) have an unfavorable opinion of the country and those with a college degree are more likely to hold an unfavorable view than those with some college or less. I sense that within this fevered smearing of “evil” China is an implicit war-mongering message: Something must be done to stop China’s rise in the world. Whether exposure to relentless Sino-phobia will translate into public support for an actual war should never be assumed. It leaves a very narrow and perhaps only temporary opening for counter-narratives that might preserve BRI as an antidote to Western imperialism while increasing the chances for “a human community with a shared destiny.”

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G7 countries only contain 10 percent of the world’s population while their combined Gross Domestic Product (GDP is merely 27 percent of the global GDP. These are demographically and increasingly economically marginalized states that want to use their authority, partly derived from their military power, to control the world order.

—Vijay Prashad

Striking Power: How Temple University Graduate Student Workers Won a New Contract

ALEXANDER FISCHER

The Temple University Graduate Student Association (TUGSA 6290), a union that represents more than 750 graduate student workers at Temple struck for over a month from late January to early March 2023. TUGSA, the only graduate student union in Pennsylvania, demanded a living wage, greater parental and bereavement leave, and dependent healthcare. Founded in 1997, this marked the first time TUGSA voted to authorize a strike, the first graduate student-worker strike in Pennsylvania history.

TUGSA’s Initial Demands

Temple graduate student workers, comprised of TAs (teaching assistants), RAs (research assistants), and IORs (instructors of record) across non-medical and non-law-related colleges were working without a contract for over a year, still on the terms of the previous outdated four-year contract with pay of \$19,500 per year, with less than one week (each) of parental and bereavement leave, and no option for dependent healthcare coverage.

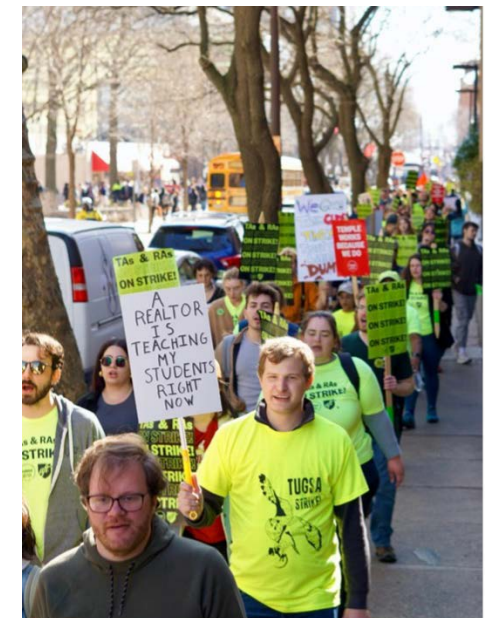
TUGSA’s initial demands were:

- \$32,800 per year (based on, but still less than, the cost of living in Philadelphia in 2022)
- Full healthcare premium coverage for all dependents
- 6 weeks of parental leave
- Bereavement leave: Include grandparents as “immediate” family and provide an additional seven days for international travel

A study by the Century Foundation found that Temple University spends just \$0.62 of every tuition dollar on instruction, the lowest of any “R1” public university in the country.

TUGSA Actualizes the November Vote to Authorize a Strike

Graduate students at Temple worked without a contract for over a year after Temple’s administration halted contract negotiations with TUGSA in February of 2022. In November of 2022, after months of organizing, educating, and agitating



Striking TUGSA members march with undergraduate students on Broad St. in North Central Philadelphia. Photo: TUGSA member Dan Confalone.

within and across the union, 99% of TUGSA members voted to authorize a strike for the first time in TUGSA's history. The strike was officially called on January 31, only two weeks into the 2022 Spring semester.

The strike gained wide support from the outset and remained widely supported on campus and by the public. It also continued to receive positive regional, local, and alternative media coverage from *CBS*, *ABC*, *The Philadelphia Inquirer*, and *DemocracyNow!*, though TUGSA did not receive significant nor sustained national media attention during the strike articles did appear in the more widely read venues: *CNN*'s opinion section, and *Politico*. The strike was, however, quickly thrust into the spotlight with support from TUGSA's parent union, the American Federation of Teachers (AFT) and its President Randi Weingarten, Philadelphia mayoral candidates, Vermont Senator Bernie Sanders, newly elected Pennsylvania Senator John Fetterman, as well as other state and local representatives, and local union chapters including Philadelphia's local AFL-CIO and Teamsters.

Union Busting: Temple Intimidates and Retaliates

Temple wasted no time retaliating. On February 4, less than one week into the strike, striking graduate students had their healthcare terminated—a tactic rarely if ever used by universities to suppress a strike. Most graduate students only became aware of this as news began to spread that people were denied their medical visits at doctor's offices and their prescriptions at the pharmacy. Temple did email students before strike authorization notifying workers that this was an option, an intimidation tactic at a time when the university refused to negotiate with the union, although they were aware of TUGSA activity and the democratic processes within the union regarding pre-strike authorization and strike deliberation. No student, however, was notified directly by email that the university discovered they were striking and was indeed optioning for terminating their healthcare.

Healthcare at Temple is a student benefit, meaning every student has the option to buy healthcare through the university; It is not necessarily tied to worker status except to the extent that it is subsidized for graduate student workers because of their worker status. This is important because striking TUGSA members (because we are still students) *can* have their healthcare reinstated (with the subsidy in abeyance), by requesting this of HR, although Temple processes each case individually. My healthcare coverage, and the coverage of countless others was not reinstated by the university until the strike ended, although we had made formal requests.

Four days after our healthcare was terminated, striking workers' tuition remission (a standard for Ph.D. students across the U.S.) was revoked and students were prompted with an overdue tuition bill. Each student was sent an email informing us that our tuition remission was revoked due to our participation in the strike, and that we had outstanding tuition balances due by March 9 or we would incur a late fee and financial "hold" on our account. In addition, there have been cases wherein students who borrow federal loans to supplement their low pay (and many do), had their FAFSA loans seized by the university to be used to pay the tuition balance that resulted from revoked tuition remission. Retaliation did not stop there.

International students faced the brunt of Temple's intimidation tactics, as it was suggested to them, in a deliberately convoluted and confusing manner (and with no legal basis) that they could be *deported* for striking. One student's testimony at a rally noted that this email stated that "penalties for failing to follow the rules will result in [revocation of] F1 [immigration] status and all related benefits and could lead to removal and deportation from the United States."

On top of these retaliatory and intimidating measures, Temple immediately began the search for scabs to teach the classes of those of us who are instructors—a violation of our previous collective bargaining agreement. Some scabbed classes even moved online, like mine, and some were reportedly scabbed by people not qualified in the field. All graduate workers are covered under TUGSA's contracts, but only striking workers have been retaliated against—an age-old tactic to divide and discipline labor.

TUGSA Strengthened in Face of Union Busting

While TUGSA represents over 750 graduate students in its bargaining unit, a conservative estimate of union density is somewhere near 60%, meaning there are somewhere around 450 dues-paying members. Density varies from semester to semester, mostly due to students graduating out of the union or their worker status changing to fellowship or dissertation completion. However, density was not that high pre-pandemic, as TUGSA members have worked tirelessly to increase the ranks over the last year or so.

Despite Temple's retaliatory tactics, the strike grew with time, as at least 250 graduate student workers ended up participating in the strike, or just greater than one-in-every three (non-medical, non-law affiliated) graduate student workers at the university. In addition to support from political leaders and other unions, TUGSA was very well-supported by undergraduate students at Temple. Just two weeks into the strike, more than 1,000 undergraduate students participated in a walk-out from their classes to join us on the picket line and to rally. Undergraduate support continued to grow, assisted by TUGSA's "strike classes," which were held on campus Monday through Friday to inform students and passersby about the strike and how they could support it. TUGSA eventually gained support from some faculty at the university, and their union (TAUP, Temple Association of University Professionals), but the union believes that this was not quite enough to pressure the administration and that daily picket lines, undergraduate support, bad press, and local and state-level union and political support helped win the day.

Rather than dividing the union and souring the relationship between undergraduate students and TUGSA, retaliation backfired, proving that well-organized unions who value their right to strike, transparency and information-sharing, and horizontal decision-making can remain steadfast. TUGSA's resilience finally forced Temple's administration back to the bargaining table, only for TUGSA to overwhelmingly reject their first formal offer in over a year, on February 21st.

TUGSA Rejects the First Tentative Agreement

After two-and-a-half weeks of striking, picketing, and rallying, the Temple administration agreed to resume negotiations. After a few days of negotiation,

TUGSA's negotiating team put forward a "tentative agreement" offered by the university to a vote for union members. The tentative agreement proposed a one-time \$1,000 bonus in 2023 and \$22,000 in salary for the first year. The offer would have increased the average salary to \$23,500 by the end of the four-year contract—in 2027. It included *no* dependent healthcare coverage.

The following results were read the evening of February 21st: with 83% of eligible voters voting, TUGSA voted by over 92% to reject the offer, with 352 No votes to only 30 Yes votes.

Unsurprisingly, before the team even left the room, the Temple administration had already leaked information to the public. This led to the *Philadelphia Inquirer* reporting that a deal had been reached and that the strike would be "coming to an end," or so its author tweeted, before the university's email about the agreement going out. (The article had since been updated).

Despite Temple's anti-labor tactics, the TUGSA negotiating team was nonetheless surprised to learn of this after they left the meeting with the administration. Continuing with its false narratives and corporate spin, Senior Vice President of Temple, Ken Kaiser sent an email to the entire campus which made it appear as if the dust had settled. Kaiser's email implied that an agreement had been reached, and, as if we took a vacation, that striking students were "welcomed back" to their respective duties. Not only was the first offer rejected outright, but many instructors were never "welcomed" back to their original duties. In my case, even when the strike ended, I was formally relieved of my instructing duties and issued new work assignments for the semester as the scab who was hired when I went on strike finished teaching my former classes online.

More Striking, a Visit to Harrisburg, and a New Contract

After TUGSA rejected the first offer, the strike continued as did local and regional support. The union maintained strong picket lines across campus every day and continued to organize campaigns and end-of-day rallies to gain support, including stopping traffic for short periods on North Broad Street to gain wider support from the local Philadelphia passersby. Moving towards the one-month mark of striking, each day of picketing was critical to continue to display the union's physical presence and power on campus and in the media.

After 34 days on strike, a few dozen TUGSA members drove to Harrisburg on March 6 to rally for support and speak with house members. TUGSA was welcomed and received critical public support from various Senate and House members such as PA Sen. John Kane, Reps. Malcolm Kenyatta and Dan Miller. Within *three* days of this meeting, Temple Administration hashed out a second offer on a new four-year contract.

Before voting, union members debated the agreement on its terms but also wrestled with political strategy. Not only were the striking union members in limbo, but they were losing income, had no healthcare, were experiencing strike fatigue, and were facing a not-so-well-endowed strike fund. We were also dealing with the reality of having built up political support coinciding with bad press for the university. Striking members faced some universal yet unique features of withholding labor. With

only one-third of the union on strike, we strategized on the benefits of continuing to strike under such circumstances. This unique scenario, combined with a shift in the terms of the agreement led to an open and deliberative caucusing process to discuss terms and strategies together.

After four days of voting and 42 days on strike, TUGSA members voted overwhelmingly to ratify the March 9 agreement, which consisted of the following: Reinstatement of tuition remission *effective immediately*

- Reinstatement of healthcare *effective immediately*
- One-time \$500 bonus *effectively immediately*
- Pro-rated March pay from the date the accepted agreement was offered
- A wage increase to \$24,000 in the first year (*effective immediately*), gradually increasing to \$27,000 by 2026
- Abolition of pay tiers within and across disciplines
- Half premium coverage for dependent healthcare
- Increased bereavement leave and extended time for international travel

While TUGSA had to compromise on its initial demands, and while the pay increase by 2027 will hardly appear as a win when factoring in both inflation and the devaluing of the purchasing power of the Temple graduate student worker wage (having been stagnant), or when compared to our comrades across the way at the University of Pennsylvania, or our striking comrades in Michigan. Nonetheless, one-third of TUGSA members went on strike and won the above benefits for nearly eight-hundred graduate student workers at Temple University, a factor which increases the value of the inner city working class position of graduate student worker at Temple University in the eyes of incoming students. Striking workers set a precedent for TUGSA and Universities across Pennsylvania, demonstrating labor's political power, even when only one-third of union members participate in striking, and even fewer show up on the picket line—issues TUGSA will continue to address through union consciousness-raising efforts and material gains such as the new contract.

TUGSA's success ripples throughout a nation experiencing rates of labor unrest in academia not seen in two decades. TUGSA's strike follows threatened student-worker strikes at in Temple's hospital network, graduate student-worker strikes at the University of California, and has been followed by a successful strike at Rutgers University in New Jersey, and a graduate student-worker strike at the University of Michigan which continues well into its third month after having begun on March 29.

The new four-year contracts TUGSA agreed to were ultimately short of our ultimate demands. However, TUGSA has set a precedent for graduate student workers striking in Pennsylvania and demonstrated graduate student workers' political power to the nation by withholding their labor and striking for a living wage as well as other benefits viewed by most workers as *human rights*.

Alex Fischer graduated from Moravian University, completed his Masters at Lehigh University, and is now a PhD student in Political Science at Temple University.

Nuclear Fusion: Eternal Energy = Eternal Damnation

DON FITZ AND STAN COX

Like a third-rate zombie movie on Netflix, delusions of nuclear fusion repeatedly rise from the dead. The cover story in the June 2023 issue of [Scientific American](#) by Philip Ball, “Star Power: Does Fusion Have a Future After All?” recycles the corporate line which was broadcast on December 13, 2022. The US Department of Energy (DOE) announced that the National Ignition Facility (NIF) at the Lawrence Livermore National Laboratory had reached a “breakthrough” in developing an alternative to fission.

As Joshua Frank described the [hype](#) over nuclear fusion...

“... there’s no toxic mining involved, nor do thousands of gallons of cold water have to be pumped into cool overheated reactors, nor will there be radioactive waste byproducts lasting hundreds of thousands of years. And not a risk of a nuclear meltdown in sight! Fusion, so the cheery news went, is safe, effective, and efficient!”

Six months after the announcement was debunked, the *Scientific American* article admitted some of the inherent faults with fusion, repeated some of the original misstatements, and went on with detailed descriptions of technical tweaks necessary to make the technology viable in the second half of the century. Unfortunately, most of those who criticized fusion missed one of its most serious dangers—that discovering a source of limitless cheap energy would doom humanity’s future rather than enhance it.

The Terror

To interpret the spin of the military-industrial-pseudo-scientific (MIPS) complex, we need to appreciate the primary obstacle to expanding nuclear power. MIPS must overcome the intense terror of nukes.

The terror began with images of Hiroshima and Nagasaki in August 1945. Photos of burnt bodies are burned into the minds of their viewers. MIPS seeks to discount the images with the myth that Japan had to be nuked, even though it was ready to surrender. The mythology continued with the “Atoms for Peace” false pretense that there could be a disconnect between nuclear power and nuclear bombs.

A few decades went by and on March 28, 1979, Three-Mile Island melted down. A good part of its infamy stemmed from repeated government lies that the event was not so serious and would have few long-lasting effects. Americans would never be convinced that nukes would only be dangerous if the Soviets or Japanese built them.

Then there was Chernobyl on April 26, 1986. In 2009 the New York Academy of Science published a detailed analysis estimating the total death count to be around 900,000 and the MIPS spewed forth venomous claims that it was not actually so bad but was merely the worst human-caused catastrophe in history.

This was followed on March 11, 2011, with the [Fukushima Daiichi](#) apocalypse when 3 of 6 nuclear reactors melted down, spreading radioactivity into the neighbor-

ing Pacific Ocean and poisoning unknown quantities of aquatic life. So, each generation from World War II through today has memories of horrendous nuclear events which MIPS has been totally unsuccessful at erasing.

But credit should be given where it is due, and there is an area where MIPS has done quite well in its plugola efforts. Those efforts have been to keep everyday leakage of nuclear material and “smaller” catastrophes either out of or reduced to short paragraphs in the corporate press. Few know that “100 [significant accidents](#) happened in the world’s nuclear power plants from the mid-1950s to 2010.” The world’s press has given scant attention to how people were used as guinea pigs in testing sites such as the Marshall Islands. Souma Dutta notes such [events](#): “... in the Soviet nuclear test sites of Semipalatinsk in Kazakhstan, Novaya Zemlya, and others, the French nuclear test sites of Reggane & Akker in Algeria and the Mururoa Atoll in the Pacific, the British test sites in the Australian territories of Monte Bello, Maralinga, Emu Field, and the Chinese test site of Lop Nur.”

Denial Non-Stop

The *Scientific American* article lets us know which dangers of nuclear fusion MIPS continues to deny six months after the NIF “breakthrough.” Despite a good amount of evidence to the contrary, the article claims that nuclear fusion would (a) produce “near zero carbon emissions” but (b) “without creating the dangerous radioactive waste.”

Though significant carbon emissions may not be produced during the immediate process of creating energy either through fission or fusion, considerable emissions are associated with producing and transporting the very large amount of equipment used in the life cycle of nukes. Additionally, Stan carefully documents that, despite the myth that increases in solar, wind, and nuclear power result in a decrease in [fossil fuel use](#), “History and research tell us that a buildup of new energy capacity won’t flush oil and fossil gas out of the system.”

That is hardly likely to change because solar power is nowhere close to “[reproducing itself](#).” According to T. Vijayendra: “... the first ton of coal was extracted using human and animal muscle power. But soon, machines driven by coal energy were producing the capital equipment necessary to extract coal. This is not the case with solar energy. All the necessary equipment, including solar collectors, are produced through processes based on sources of energy other than the sun (coal, oil, uranium, etc.).”

Please remember that the goal of corporations is profit. That requires expanding production by increasing the amount of energy used to the maximum. If fusion were added to the energy mix, there would continue to be little to no decrease in fossil fuel use.

Equally fallacious is the claim that nuclear fusion would not result in deadly waste. Essential for the fusion process is [tritium](#), a radioactive form of hydrogen. Its isotopes can permeate metals and pass through the tiniest spaces in enclosures. Since tritium can enter virtually any part of the human body, it can lead to a variety of [cancers](#).

Nuclear fusion would be even more inefficient at water use than would fission reactors. Though not exactly a “waste product,” this wastage would seriously [drain water supplies](#) at a time when they are increasingly being exhausted.

Dirty Little Secrets Creep into the Open

Philip Ball's article slyly [admits](#) the accuracy of several of the most frequent criticisms of the December 2022 "breakthrough" announcement. They appear as a hint to the MIPS complex that, in order to manufacture consent on the grandeur of nuclear fusion, its acolytes should modify some of their more outlandish claims if they are to be taken seriously.

First, nuclear fusion is far, far too expensive to provide energy "too cheap to meter" during the upcoming decades. Not only is tritium (costing [\\$30,000 per gram](#)) necessary to start the initial reaction, reactors must be lined with expensive lithium. The equipment to make the tiny event happen is enormous, requiring space equal to [three football fields](#). The complexity of the system requires twice as many [employees](#)—1000 for fusion vs. 500 for a fission reactor. This helps explain why original cost projections of \$6.3 billion mushroomed to DOE's current estimate of [\\$65 billion](#).

Second, closely linked to cost is the contrast between the minuscule amount of electricity squeezed out with the use of 192 lasers in December 2022 and the gargantuan amount that would be needed to feed the grid. According to Brian Tokar, the Livermore blast lasted one ten-billionth [second](#). Nowhere close to powering a major city for a year, a month, or even an hour.

Third, the cost for such a frivolous amount of energy means that no one seriously suggests that fusion reactors will power homes in the foreseeable future. Many proponents now openly admit that claiming that technology will be used to improve people's lives is a hoax. Ball quotes an industry spokesperson [bluntly stating](#) that "There is not today a single project underway to build a fusion power plant that will produce energy."

Fourth, the real reason for the race to fusion is to allow the stockpiling of nuclear weapons that are even more dreadful than present ones. Currently, a major difficulty in manufacturing nuclear bombs is "the need for highly enriched [uranium or plutonium](#)" to initiate the reaction. Research with nuclear fusion could provide an alternative path to accomplish the ignition.

Dr. M.V Ramana explains the search for "neutrons with the very short pulse widths characteristic of low-yield nuclear intercepts that can be used to establish [lethal criteria](#) for chemical/biological agents and nuclear warhead targets." Thus, if experimentation with nuclear fusion were to be successful, it could further shorten the Doomsday Clock, increasing the probability of human annihilation.

To Dream the Impossible Dream

Critiquing fusion on the basis that "It won't work" has the subtle but ominous implication that it might be okay if it did work. This logic comes perilously close to [Ball's view](#) that "The world is increasingly desperate for an abundant source of clean energy that can mitigate the climate crisis." The view that we must replace "bad" energy with "good" energy is omnipresent. Placing limits on energy growth does not even fit into the corporate equation.

Let's strip away the "bads" from nuclear fusion for a moment and ask, "What would it be like to have alternative energy that was not excessively costly, did not damage the health of humans or other species, had zero carbon emissions throughout

its production life cycle, could produce as much energy as we would ever want, and was not a con game for nuclear war?"

Such a quest for limitless energy is a journey into oblivion. To dream the impossible energy dream is to hallucinate the most hideous nightmare. Richard Heinberg warns of the dangers of ignoring limits, noting that if nuke fusion were to remove limits on energy production, corporations would expand production to endlessly deplete the soil and habitats.

Searching for infinite energy other than fossil fuels would present dangers as ominous as nuclear war. Christopher Ketcham summarizes:

"mainstream environmentalists have siloed climate change as a phenomenon apart from the broad human ecological footprint, separate from deforestation, overgrazing of livestock, megafauna kill-off, collapsing fisheries, desertification, depleted freshwater, soil degradation, oceanic garbage gyres, toxification of rainfall with microplastics, and on and on—the myriad biospheric effects of [breakneck growth](#)."

The attitude that "nothing is as threatening as climate change" has lured many into the abyss of ignoring (or minimizing) the humongous dangers of "alternative" energy (AltE). Stan explains how [AltE contributes](#) to ongoing threats, writing that the total quantity of "human-made mass"—which is everything made by people—has now exceeded "the total weight of all living plant, animal, and microbial biomass on Earth." This material mass is [doubling](#) every 20 years, it contributes to the "breakdown of entire ecosystems" as well as climate change.

Just a few examples. Each wind turbine requires more than 60 pounds of metal—and their numbers are growing exponentially. [Electric vehicles](#) swallow "hundreds of millions of tons of lithium-ion batteries for power storage." If the world economy is to continue growing, while it converts to running fully on electricity from AltE sources later this century, the quantity of metals that will have to be extracted and processed during the next 15 years will [exceed](#) the amount produced for the last 5,000 years. This will ignite an explosion in the number of mines and devastate entire ecosystems. It is an open question of whether uncontrolled economic growth, climate change, or nuclear war will trigger the demise of human civilization. The quest for eternal energy is the basis of eternal growth which becomes the altar of eternal damnation.

The good news is that it does not have to be like this. We now have the knowledge and ability to provide good lives for people throughout the world if we have the sense to distinguish what humanity needs vs. what corporations are greedy for.

Do we really need to build rocket ships to Mars? Is the quality of our lives improved by having products that fall apart sooner and sooner? Must there be a car for every adult on Earth instead of having communities where people get 80% of what they use by walking or cycling?

Are Americans really safer by having over 700 military bases and the ability to exterminate every human many times over? Don's book *Cuban Health Care* documents how that country's medical system produces less infant mortality and a longer

life expectancy than the US while spending less than 10% of what the US spends per person annually.

Contrary to widespread propaganda, humanity does not desperately need more energy. We desperately need to live better with less energy.

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A record number of homeless people are dying on the streets. For example, whereas 64 had died in San Diego in 2014 now nearly 600 do. I like to think people care about one another, and perhaps many do, but why do we tolerate such a heartless system?

—Faramarz Farbod

The Emergence of a New Non-Alignment

VIJAY PRASHAD

A new mood of defiance in the Global South has generated bewilderment in the Acapitals of the [Triad](#) (the United States, Europe, and Japan), where officials are struggling to answer why governments in the Global South have not [accepted](#) the Western view of the conflict in Ukraine or universally supported the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation (NATO) in its efforts to [‘weaken Russia’](#). Governments that had long been pliant to the Triad’s wishes, such as the administrations of Narendra Modi in India and Recep Tayyip Erdoğan in Türkiye (despite the toxicity of their own regimes), are no longer as reliable.

Since the start of the war in Ukraine, India’s Foreign Minister S. Jaishankar has been vocal in defending his government’s refusal to accede to Washington’s pressure. In April 2022, at a joint press conference in Washington, DC with US Secretary of State Antony Blinken, Jaishankar was asked to explain India’s continued purchase of oil from Russia. His [answer](#) was blunt: ‘I noticed you refer to oil purchases. If you are looking at energy purchases from Russia, I would suggest that your attention should be focused on Europe... We do buy some energy which is necessary for our energy security. But I suspect, looking at the figures, probably our total purchases for the month would be less than what Europe does in an afternoon’.



Kandji Narsimlu (India), *Waiting at the Bus Stand*, 2023.

However, such comments have not deterred Washington's efforts to win India over to its agenda. On 24 May, the [US Congress's Select Committee on the Chinese Communist Party](#) released a policy [statement](#) on Taiwan which asserted that '[t]he United States should strengthen the NATO Plus arrangement to include India'. This policy statement was released shortly after the G7 [summit](#) in Hiroshima, Japan, where India's Prime Minister Narendra Modi met with the various G7 leaders, including US President Joe Biden, as well as Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy.

The Indian government's response to this 'NATO Plus' formulation echoed the sentiment of its earlier remarks about purchasing Russian oil. 'A lot of Americans still have that NATO treaty construct in their heads', Jaishankar [said](#) in a press conference on 9 June. 'It seems almost like that is the only template or viewpoint with which they look at the world... That is not a template that applies to India'. India, he said, is not interested in being part of NATO Plus, wishing to maintain a greater degree of geopolitical flexibility. 'One of the challenges of a changing world', Jaishankar said, 'is how do you get people to accept and adjust to those changes'.

There are two significant takeaways from Jaishankar's statements. First, the Indian government—which does not oppose the United States, either in terms of its program or temperament—is uninterested in being drawn into a US-led bloc system (the 'NATO treaty construct', as Jaishankar put it). Second, like many governments in the Global South, it recognizes that we live in a 'changing world' and that the traditional major powers—especially the United States—need to 'adjust to those changes'.

In its Investment Outlook 2023 report, Credit Suisse [pointed](#) to the 'deep and persistent fractures' that have opened up in the international order—another way of referring to what Jaishankar called the 'changing world'. Credit Suisse describes these 'fractures' accurately: 'The global West (Western developed countries and allies) has drifted away from the global East (China, Russia, and allies) in terms of core strategic interests, while the Global South (Brazil, Russia, India, and China and most developing countries) is reorganizing to pursue its own interests'. These final words bear repeating: 'the Global South... is reorganizing to pursue its own interests'.

In mid-April, the Japanese Ministry of Foreign Affairs released its [Diplomatic Bluebook 2023](#), in which it noted that we are now at the 'end of the post-Cold War era'. After the Soviet Union collapsed in 1991, the United States asserted its primacy over the international order and, along with its Triad vassals, established what it called the '[rules-based international order](#)'. This thirty-year-old US-led project is now floundering, partly due to the internal weaknesses of the Triad countries (including their weakened position in the global economy) and partly due to the rise of the '[locomotives of the South](#)' (led by China, but including Brazil, India, Indonesia, Mexico, and Nigeria). Our calculations, based on the [IMF datamapper](#), show that for the first time in centuries, the Gross Domestic Product of the Global South countries surpassed that of the Global North countries this year. The rise of these developing countries—despite the great social inequality that exists within them—has produced a new attitude amongst their middle classes which is reflected in the increased confidence of their governments: they no longer accept the parochial views of the

Triad countries as universal truths, and they have a greater wish to exert their own national and regional interests.

It is this re-assertion of national and regional interests within the Global South that has revived a set of regional processes, including the Community of Latin American and Caribbean States ([CELAC](#)) and the BRICS (Brazil-Russia-India-China-South Africa) process. On 1 June, the BRICS foreign ministers met in Cape Town (South Africa) ahead of the summit between their heads of states that is set to take place this August in Johannesburg. The joint statement they issued is instructive: twice, they warned about the negative impact of 'unilateral economic coercive measures, such as sanctions, boycotts, embargoes, and blockades' which have 'produced negative effects, notably in the developing world'. The language in this statement represents a feeling that is shared across the entirety of the Global South. From Bolivia to Sri Lanka, these countries, which make up the majority of the world, are fed up with the [IMF-driven debt-austerity cycle](#) and the Triad's bullying. They are beginning to assert their own sovereign agendas.

Interestingly, this revival of sovereign politics is not being driven by inward-looking nationalism, but by a non-aligned internationalism. The BRICS ministers' statement focuses on 'strengthening multilateralism and upholding international law, including the purposes and principles enshrined in the Charter of the United Nations as its indispensable cornerstone' (incidentally, both China and Russia are part of the twenty-member [Group of Friends in Defence of the UN Charter](#)). The implicit argument being made here is that the US-led Triad states have unilaterally imposed their narrow worldview, based on the interests of their elites, on the countries of the South under the guise of the 'rules-based international order'. Now, the states of the Global



*Leaders of the Third World at the first conference of the Non-Aligned Movement in Belgrade, 1961.
Credit: Museum of Yugoslavia, Belgrade.*

South argue, it is time to return to the source—the UN Charter—and build a genuinely democratic international order.

The word ‘non-aligned’ has increasingly been used to refer to this new trend in international politics. The term has its origins in the Non-Aligned Conference held in Belgrade (Yugoslavia) in 1961, which was built upon the foundations laid at the Asian-African Conference held in Bandung (Indonesia) in 1955. In those days, non-alignment referred to countries led by movements rooted in the deeply anti-colonial Third World Project, which sought to establish the sovereignty of the new states and the dignity of their people. That moment of non-alignment was killed off by the debt crisis of the 1980s, which began with Mexico’s default in 1982. What we have now is not a return of the old non-alignment, but the emergence of a new political atmosphere and a new political constellation that requires careful study. For now, we can say that this new non-alignment is being demanded by the larger states of the Global South that are uninterested in being subordinated by the Triad’s agenda, but which have not yet established a project of their own—a Global South Project, for instance.

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“Once you’ve been to Cambodia, you’ll never stop wanting to beat Henry Kissinger to death with your bare hands. You will never again be able to open a newspaper and read about that treacherous, prevaricating, murderous scumbag sitting down for a nice chat with Charlie Rose or attending some black-tie affair for a new glossy magazine without choking. Witness what Henry did in Cambodia—the fruits of his genius for statesmanship—and you will never understand why he’s not sitting in the dock at The Hague next to Milosevic.

—Anthony Bourdain

2 Pentagon Parties: 0% ‘debt ceiling’/1% Kabuki Theater

RAYMOND NAT TURNER

2 Pentagon Parties: 0 ‘debt ceiling’
Both war-profiteers, wheeling and dealing—
junk medal-chested generals ever concealing
what greasy-thumbed accountants are stealing

It’s Mike and Ike Kabuki Theater
Where Ol’ Schmo is some smooth operator
Insurance-Bank bailout activator—
Reducing us to: Passive Spectator...

2 Pentagon Parties: 0 ‘debt ceiling’
“Medicare for ALL?! Why, that’s unappealing—
astronomical costs send us reeling!!
You must rely solely on self-healing...”

It’s Mike and Ike Kabuki Theater
Where Ol’ Schmo is some smooth operator
Insurance-Bank bailout activator—
Reducing us to: Passive Spectator...

2 Pentagon Parties: 0 ‘debt ceiling’
“Affordable Housing?! That, we’re not feeling...
“Free Education?!” Hear the pigs squealing?
2 Pentagon Parties: 0 ‘debt ceiling’

Former forklift driver/warehouse worker/janitor, Raymond Nat Turner is a NYC poet; BAR’s Poet-in-Residence; and founder/co-leader of the jazz-poetry ensemble UpSurge!NYC. [Read other articles by Raymond Nat](#), or [visit Raymond Nat’s website](#).

Is cruelty Governor Woke Smoke's superpower?

RAYMOND NAT TURNER

Hey, amigo, this ain't Gitmo... We won't waterboard you.
We won't force feed you—Hop on this shiny white bus to
a better life! Catch this sleek private plane to food, clothing
and shelter! Hey, señora, one plush seat's left for you and yours!

We swear this ain't Sunshine State slapstick! We swear
it ain't Lone Star State Abbot and Costello—comedy of
Cruelty! ...Why... we'd never score \$election points with
Corporate paymasters...by using you as \$campaign props...

Why, we'd never ever move men, women, children across
this confederate chessboard like bipartisan pawns—Swear we
Wouldn't! We're not the same bloodthirsty Europeans who gun-
smoked plains, prairies, and wetlands, creating crimson clouds.

Hey, amigo, this ain't Gitmo... We won't waterboard you.
We won't force feed you—Hop on this shiny white bus to
a better life! Catch this sleek private plane to food, clothing
and shelter! Hey, señora, one plush seat's left for you and yours!

We swear this ain't Sunshine State slapstick! We swear
it ain't Lone Star State Abbot and Costello—comedy of
Cruelty! We're not the ones who blood-soaked this soil—
leaving Indigenous ones with stand stolen ground nightmares...

Why, we wouldn't lie—just ask the Seminoles! We've changed.
We're simply not the same predatory Europeans exploring Africa,
Promising, "Jobs! Jobs! Longterm Employment Opportunities!"
Trust us, "Voluntary Relocation" can live "Where woke goes to die."

Trust us... We' re... "like a good neighbor." Like Allstate following
fires in California—or floods in Florida...We'd never use pandemic
Recovery Funds (earmarked for relief) to ship you people to woke
'Sanctuary Cities!' Oh—no—Never!

Hey, amigo, this ain't Gitmo... We won't waterboard you.
We won't force feed you. This is a melting pot! You and your family
just jump right in! Trust us... we aren't the AI-driven, rightwing, robotic,
Brooks Brothers' suited barbarians your growling gut's saying we are...

*Former forklift driver/warehouse worker/janitor, Raymond Nat Turner is a NYC
poet; BAR's Poet-in-Residence; and founder/co-leader of the jazz-poetry ensemble
UpSurge!NYC. [Read other articles by Raymond Nat](#), or [visit Raymond Nat's website](#).*

sponsible for the exposed official crimes free to do as they please. In this regard, it is important to realize that the reason the US is prosecuting Assange is deeply nefarious. It is not just about revenge or the punishment of Assange for his past 'sins.' It is about shielding the US empire as well as the inner workings of the national security state at home from any future exposures, embarrassments, and challenges.

Unfortunately for Assange, the First Amendment, press freedom, and truth-tellers in general, we are not likely to see anytime soon an aroused US public in defense of Assange. The massive US hypocrisy in plain sight seems not to affect the public in the slightest thus allowing the US to seek prosecution of Assange as it continues to lecture the world about the values of democracy, a free press, and the rule of law.

Lastly, we note that Assange is not a US citizen and is not under any obligation to avoid publishing war crimes or other damaging or embarrassing classified information to the US national security state that is also of public value. To accuse him of violating the Espionage Act is simply absurd. It indicates that the US is a rogue state and will act to ensure that even non-US persons must be loyal to the US national security state or face the prospect of prolonged psychological and physical destruction.

Unless we cry out "We are all Julian Assange," his fate will be ours too.

We Ain't Seen Nothin Yet. This is so even though the 500 Canadian fires, half of which are not under control, have burned an area nearly as large as Austria. Some 110 million North Americans are experiencing extreme heat. Millions of others are and will deal with air pollution from the fires for several months to come. Global air temperature, the ocean temperature, the melting of Antarctica ice, and the rising CO2 levels are all at record highs this year. So are the profits of 5 oil companies in 2022, reaching a historic record of \$200 billion, nearly doubling the 2021 level. Texas is maybe on the verge of an electrical grid collapse, which would mean widespread deaths from extreme heat. Meanwhile, our rulers and the corporate media, who love ruinous wars and wasteful militarism, assure us that they are in control. But, the illusion of normalcy can last only so long in the face of the looming climate collapse.

How do you know the US doesn't care about human life in the Ukraine War? Well, one way is to notice that the US is sending depleted uranium (DU) tank shells to Ukraine. DU is the dense material left behind after nuclear enrichment. It is radioactive with a half-life of 4.5 billion years. It is hazardous to health if ingested or inhaled as dust or shrapnel. It also can contaminate water and soil. The US used it in the Iraq War too. So much for the claim of "liberating" the Iraqis. I mean, Would You use radioactive weapons to free a people from a dictator, invaders, or occupiers?

How Screwed Up Is The World Order? One Indication: Africa, arguably with the greatest health care needs in comparison to other parts of the world, spends more on debt service costs (paid to the global financial institutions) than on health care.

Join us via Zoom 6:30–8:30 PM on Fridays
for political discussions and Thursdays to watch
and discuss significant films and politics.

(Zoom link moravian.zoom.us/j/8075321907)



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Check out our sister publication!



The Alliance's *Sustainable Lehigh Valley* booklet now features creative writing and visual art in addition to essays, plus information about local organizations that help make our communities more sustainable.

While the sciences provide knowledge to make key decisions, they often fail to capture people's interest or help us see the ethical and moral dimensions. Stories, poetry, and visual art catch people's attention—and boost real difference in engagement and awareness.



STOP THIS —by Mr. Fish

Every time we witness an injustice and do not act, we train our character to be passive in its presence and thereby eventually lose all ability to defend ourselves and those we love.

—Julian Assange